



Four Decades of Educational Excellence

FACULTY OF PEACE STUDIES

Study Material

Foundation of Peace

Course Code: PCE10010

Transform Your Life, Transform the World Around

**Proponent of
World Peace**

Vision:

**“Union of Science and
Spirituality alone will
bring peace to mankind”**

Holistic way of living



- Hon. Revered Prof.(Dr.) Vishwanath D. Karad,
Founder President, MIT World Peace University,
UNESCO CHAIR for Human Rights, Democracy
and Peace

Upholding
Democratic
Ideals

Mission:

**To
Create
Globally Responsible,
Mindful and
Peaceful leaders.**



Hon. Dr. Rahul V. Karad. Managing
Trustee and Executive President,
MIT-WPU, MAEERS Group of
Institutions.

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Why Peace

What is Peace Education:

- Betty Reardon (Comprehensive Peace Education: Educating for global Responsibility, 1988) reminds that peace education has an important social purpose: it seeks to transform the present human condition by “changing social structures and patterns of thought that have created it.”
- Learning to Abolish War; Teaching toward a Culture of Peace (Reardon and Cabezudo, 2002), the main purpose of peace education are the elimination of social injustice, the rejection of violence and the abolition of war.

Why Peace Education?

1. Contribution of Peace Education in Social Transformation:

Fostering Understanding: Peace education promotes a deep understanding of the root causes of conflicts and violence. It helps individuals comprehend the complexities of social issues, promoting empathy and tolerance among diverse groups.

Conflict Resolution Skills: Peace education equips individuals with nonviolent conflict resolution skills. This is crucial in fostering positive social changes, as it enables people to address disagreements without resorting to violence, thus contributing to a more harmonious society.

Promoting Social Justice: By educating individuals about structural arrangements that produce and legitimize injustice and inequality, peace education encourages critical analysis. This critical perspective empowers individuals to identify and challenge systems that perpetuate social disparities, contributing to the quest for social justice.

2. Nonviolent Alternatives for Managing Conflict:

Communication Skills: Peace education emphasizes effective communication and active listening, essential for resolving conflicts without resorting to violence.

Negotiation and Mediation: Teaching negotiation and mediation skills provides individuals with tools to peacefully navigate disputes, fostering collaboration and understanding.

Conflict Transformation: Rather than just resolving conflicts, peace education focuses on transforming the underlying causes. It encourages individuals to address root issues to create lasting positive changes.

Skills for Critical Analysis of Structural Arrangements:

Understanding Power Dynamics: Peace education helps individuals critically analyze power structures

and hierarchies, enabling them to recognize and challenge systems that perpetuate injustice.

Advocacy Skills: Equipping individuals with skills to advocate for social change, peace education empowers them to work towards dismantling structures that contribute to inequality.

Promoting Human Rights: By fostering an understanding of human rights principles, peace education encourages individuals to identify and challenge structural arrangements that violate these rights.

People as the Greatest Resource for a Culture of Peace:

Community Engagement: Peace education recognizes that individuals within communities are the driving force for positive change. It emphasizes community involvement and collective efforts to build a culture of peace.

Civic Responsibility: Encouraging a sense of civic responsibility, peace education motivates individuals to actively participate in shaping their societies, fostering a culture of mutual respect and cooperation.

Educating Peace Agents:

Empowering Individuals: Peace education is centered around empowering individuals to become proactive agents of peace. It provides them with the knowledge, skills, and values necessary to contribute to building a peaceful society.

Promoting Global Citizenship: Peace education encourages a sense of global citizenship, emphasizing that individuals have a role in promoting peace not only in their immediate communities but also on a broader, global scale.

Empowering Young People for Positive Change:

New Perspectives: Peace education provides young people with alternative perspectives on conflict resolution, encouraging them to explore nonviolent solutions and challenging traditional approaches.

Skill Development: Young people are equipped with essential skills such as critical thinking, communication, and empathy, enabling them to contribute positively to society and address challenges constructively.

Values and Ethics: Peace education instills values of cooperation, respect, and social responsibility, shaping the ethical foundation necessary for young people to contribute to positive change and human well-being.

Concept and meaning of Peace:

The concept of 'peace' is commonly associated with the cessation or nonexistence of war. Nevertheless, within the Western tradition, the term encompasses various other interpretations. According to the Merriam-Webster Online Dictionary, peace can also be understood as:

A condition of calm or quietness within a community

Liberation from troubling or burdensome thoughts or emotions (such as inner peace or peace of mind)
Agreement and harmony in personal relationships

A state or duration of mutual agreement between governments

A formal pact or arrangement to cease hostilities.

Concepts of peace depend on the historical and cultural context, and the term has many connotations in other languages (Lewer 1992).

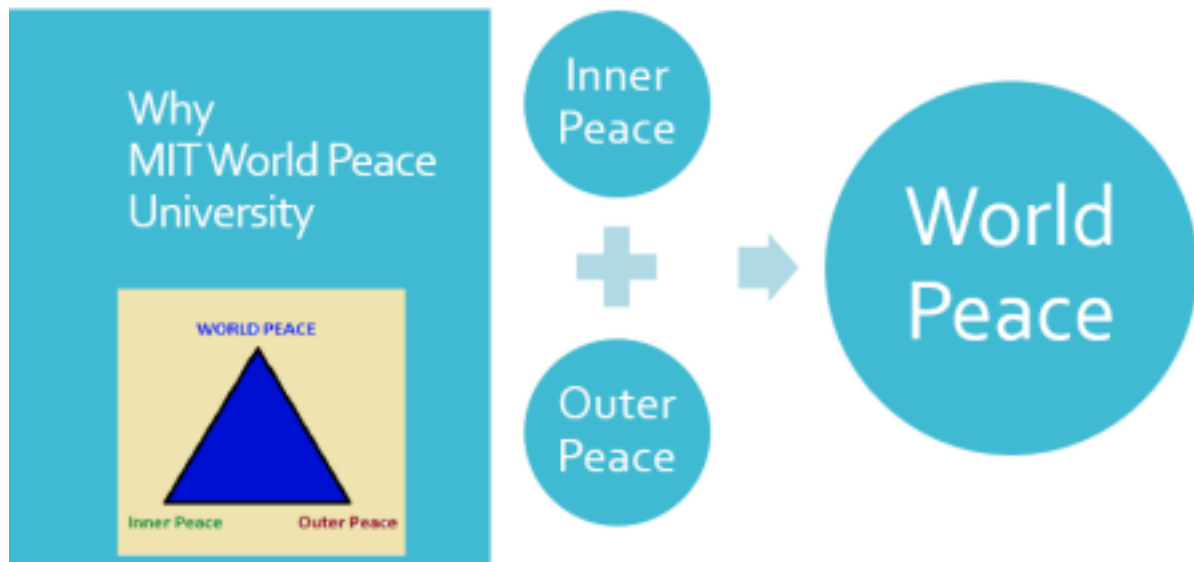
For example:

‘satyagrahavarda’ (Sanskrit) – the study of physical, mental and spiritual forces which produce

individual and social harmony

‘shalom’ (Hebrew) or ‘salaam’ (Arabic) – individual wellbeing and spiritual wholeness
‘eirene’ (Greek) – an ethical social relationship

‘pax’ (Latin) – contains the notions of law, order and mutual duty in a society



Why Peace?

Why inner peace?

Nothing can bring you peace but yourself. – Ralph Waldo Emerson

- World Peace will never be stable until enough of us find inner peace to stabilize it.
- Eternal Inner Peace has to be cultivated daily.
- Without peace of mind, life is just a shadow of its possibilities

Learn to be peaceful in the midst of chaos.

Meaning of inner peace:

- Internal peace is peace within oneself; it is derived from practicing or training of mind of an individual
- It helps address the emotions like worry, anxiety, greed, desire, hatred, ill-will, delusion and/or other defilements arising due to complexities of modern world
- Can be reached by means of prayer, meditation, wisdom and other ways.
- Internal peace is essential; it is generally regarded as true peace and as a real foundation of peace in society.

Why outer Peace:

Inner peace begins with outer peace:

- The phrase "inner peace begins with outer peace" means that achieving a peaceful state of mind and emotions **starts with creating peace and calm in the external environment.**

- In other words, it suggests that the **conditions of one's physical surroundings can have a significant impact** on their mental and emotional well-being.
- For example, if a person's external environment is cluttered, chaotic, and stressful, it can be difficult for them to find inner peace and contentment. On the other hand, if a person creates an environment that is calm, organized, and relaxing, it can help them feel more at peace and centered within themselves.
- Therefore, the phrase "inner peace begins with outer peace" **encourages individuals to focus on creating a peaceful physical environment** as a starting point for achieving overall well-being and inner peace

Take responsibility for outer peace too.

Why Peace is Relevant to us?



Do we need to also concern about:

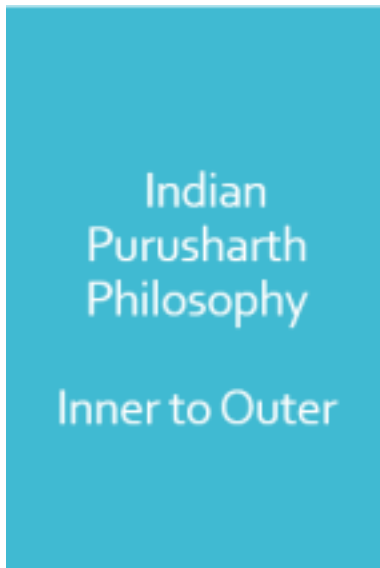
- Assault: Physical attacks on individuals with the intent to cause harm.
- Homicide: The intentional killing of another person.
 - Armed Robbery: Using weapons to forcefully steal from individuals or businesses.
- Domestic Violence: Physical abuse within intimate relationships, including spousal or partner violence.
- Street Violence: Physical altercations or fights in public spaces.
- Gang Violence: Acts of violence committed by members of criminal gangs.
- Terrorist Attacks: Deliberate acts of violence to instill fear for political, ideological, or religious purposes
- War Crimes: Acts of violence committed during armed conflicts that violate international humanitarian law.
 - Assassinations: Targeted killing of specific individuals, often for political reasons.
- School Shootings: Instances where individuals use firearms to harm others within educational institutions.

- **Bombings:** The use of explosive devices to cause destruction and harm.
- **Stabbings:** Use of knives or sharp objects to injure or kill.
 - **Physical Bullying:** Repeated physical aggression or intimidation, often in a school setting.
- **Riots:** Large-scale public disturbances involving violence, vandalism, and physical confrontations.
- **Sexual Assault:** Non-consensual sexual acts involving physical force or coercion.
- **Kidnapping:** Forcibly taking and holding individuals against their will.
- **Human Trafficking:** Physical coercion and violence used to control and exploit individuals.

Types of Peace:

- **Cultural Peace:** Harmony and understanding among different cultures and ethnic groups. Examples: Promoting cultural diversity, tolerance, and intercultural dialogue.
 - **Environmental Peace:** Harmony between human activities and the natural environment. Examples: Sustainable practices, conservation, and addressing environmental degradation.
- **Political Peace:** Stability and harmony in political structures. Examples: Good governance, democratic principles, and political stability.
- **Interpersonal Peace:** Harmony in personal relationships and interactions. Effective communication, conflict resolution, and empathy.
- **Social Peace:** A state of societal well-being with minimal social tensions. Examples: Addressing social inequalities, promoting inclusivity, and ensuring basic human needs are met.
- **Economic Peace:** Stability and equity in economic systems. Examples: Reducing poverty, promoting economic development, and addressing disparities.
- **Intrastate Peace:** Peace within a particular state or country. Examples: Addressing internal conflicts, promoting social cohesion, and ensuring political stability.
- **Interstate Peace:** Peace between different states or nations. Examples: Diplomacy, international cooperation, and the prevention of interstate conflicts.
- **Psychological Peace:** Inner calm and emotional well-being. Examples: Personal resilience, mental health, and stress reduction.
- **Justice and Legal Peace:** A state where legal systems ensure justice and fairness. Examples: Rule of law, human rights, and legal mechanisms for dispute resolution.
- **Gender Peace:** Equality and harmony between gender(s). Examples: Addressing gender-based violence, promoting gender equity, and ensuring equal opportunities.

Indian Lineage of Peace



Indian Purusharth Philosophy

Purusharth is a significant philosophical concept deeply rooted in Hinduism, representing the four fundamental goals or pursuits of human life. Derived from Sanskrit, "Purusharth" is a compound term, combining "Purusha," meaning individual soul or self, and "Artha," meaning purpose or goal. These four life objectives provide a comprehensive framework for individuals seeking a balanced and purposeful existence.

The Purusharth philosophy consists of four key pursuits:

Dharma (Righteousness and Duty):

Dharma refers to righteous living and fulfilling one's moral and social responsibilities. It emphasizes ethical conduct, duty towards oneself, society, and the cosmos. Practicing Dharma ensures harmony and balance in individual and collective life. For example, fulfilling familial obligations, maintaining integrity, and contributing to the welfare of society are considered expressions of Dharma.

Artha (Wealth and Prosperity):

Artha focuses on the pursuit of material well-being and economic prosperity. It encourages individuals to work hard, accumulate wealth, and ensure economic stability. However, it emphasizes the ethical acquisition of wealth, promoting a balanced approach to material success. Pursuing Artha involves engaging in meaningful occupations, entrepreneurship, and responsible management of resources.

Kama (Desire and Pleasure):

Kama encompasses the pursuit of sensory and aesthetic pleasures, including emotional, intellectual, and sensual experiences. It recognizes the importance of pleasure in human life but within the boundaries of morality and righteousness. Balancing desires with ethical considerations is essential for a harmonious life. For instance, enjoying art, music, literature, and healthy relationships align with the pursuit of Kama.

Moksha (Liberation and Spiritual Enlightenment):

Moksha represents the ultimate goal of life – liberation from the cycle of birth and death (samsara) and union with the divine. It involves seeking spiritual enlightenment, self-realization, and transcending worldly attachments. Practices such as meditation, self-discipline, and devotion lead towards Moksha, allowing the individual to attain a state of eternal bliss and unity with the divine.

The Purusharth philosophy underscores the importance of pursuing these goals simultaneously,

recognizing that a holistic life involves a harmonious integration of duty, wealth, pleasure, and spiritual growth. It encourages individuals to strike a balance among these pursuits, ensuring that one aspect does not overshadow the others.

This ancient philosophy continues to be relevant in contemporary times, offering individuals a timeless guide for leading a purposeful and fulfilling life. The Purusharth framework acknowledges the multidimensionality of human existence, providing a roadmap for individuals to navigate the complexities of life with wisdom, virtue, and a sense of higher purpose.

Indian Lineage of Peace

The concept of peace and the pursuit of harmonious living have deep roots in Indian philosophy and cultural traditions. The Indian lineage of peace is enriched by diverse spiritual, philosophical, and ethical teachings that span thousands of years. Here are some key aspects of the Indian lineage of peace:

Vedic Wisdom:

The Vedas, ancient Indian scriptures, contain hymns and verses promoting peace, unity, and cosmic order. The emphasis on dharma (righteousness) and ahimsa (non-violence) can be traced back to these foundational texts.

Upanishadic Philosophy:

The Upanishads, philosophical texts that explore the nature of reality and the self, emphasize inner peace through self-realization. They advocate for the understanding of the interconnectedness of all living beings.

Buddhism:

Siddhartha Gautama, the Buddha, emphasized the Four Noble Truths and the Eightfold Path as a means to attain inner peace and enlightenment. Buddhism's core principles include compassion, mindfulness, and non-attachment.

Jainism:

Jain teachings, attributed to Mahavira, emphasize non-violence (ahimsa), truthfulness, and compassion. Jains follow a path of non-violence not only in actions but also in thoughts and words.

Bhagavad Gita:

A part of the Indian epic Mahabharata, the Bhagavad Gita is a conversation between Lord Krishna and Arjuna on the battlefield. It addresses duty, righteousness, and the pursuit of inner peace amid life's challenges.

Yoga Philosophy:

The Yoga Sutras of Patanjali outline the path of yoga, which extends beyond physical postures. Yoga philosophy emphasizes ethical principles (yamas and niyamas) that contribute to personal and societal well-being.

Sufism:

Influential in India, Sufism within Islam emphasizes love, tolerance, and the mystical experience of unity with the divine. Sufi saints like Rumi and Kabir have left a profound impact on Indian spirituality.

Modern Peace Movements:

India has been home to influential peace leaders like Mahatma Gandhi, who championed non violent resistance (satyagraha) during the Indian independence movement. His philosophy of ahimsa and peace remains a powerful legacy.

Interfaith Harmony:

India's rich tapestry of religions and spiritual traditions promotes interfaith harmony. The coexistence of various faiths has contributed to a culture of tolerance, respect, and understanding.

Contemporary Spiritual Leaders:

Modern spiritual leaders, such as Sri Sri Ravi Shankar and the Dalai Lama, continue to propagate messages of peace, compassion, and mindfulness, contributing to the Indian lineage of peace.

The Indian lineage of peace is characterized by a holistic approach that encompasses individual well-being, societal harmony, and a deep understanding of the interconnectedness of all life. It continues to inspire individuals and movements globally, fostering a vision of peace that transcends borders and cultural boundaries

Negative Peace



What is negative peace?

Negative peace refers to a situation where there is no ongoing violence or open conflict, resulting in a temporary calm, often observed in a cease-fire. However, this state doesn't address the underlying issues that initially led to the conflict.

For instance, consider a region that experiences a cease-fire between two warring factions. While there may be no active fighting, the root causes of the conflict, such as territorial disputes or historical grievances, remain unaddressed.

Despite the surface calm in negative peace, the acknowledgment is that the main problems causing the conflict persist. This implies that even though things may seem stable, there is a lingering risk of future conflict due to unresolved structural or systemic issues.

As an example, think of a community that experiences a temporary lull in inter-group tensions without addressing the economic disparities or cultural misunderstandings that fueled previous conflicts. The potential for renewed tensions remains.

Negative peace also falls short in addressing broader societal goals such as social justice, equality, or sustainable solutions. It essentially signifies a state of no active war without actively working towards resolving deeper societal problems.

An example could be a society where a government enforces strict laws to prevent public demonstrations and protests, resulting in a superficial appearance of peace. However, this does not address the underlying issues of political repression or lack of representation, hindering progress towards social justice and equality.

Why negative peace is better than war:

Negative peace is viewed as a better option than violence primarily because it represents the lack of direct physical harm, such as war or active conflict. Several reasons support the preference for negative peace:

Avoidance of Direct Harm: Negative peace indicates a condition where individuals are not directly exposed to physical harm or the destructive consequences associated with war. This absence of direct violence serves to protect lives, minimize casualties, and prevent the physical and emotional trauma linked to armed conflicts.

Potential for Stability: In a state of negative peace, there is typically a temporary calm or ceasefire, creating an opportunity for stability. While it may not tackle the underlying causes of conflict, negative peace provides a period for communities and nations to regroup, recover, and engage in diplomatic efforts to address fundamental issues.

However, it is essential to recognize that negative peace falls short of being fully peaceful because it solely deals with the lack of direct physical violence. The reference to cultural and structural violence underscores that societal issues, inequalities, and injustices may persist even during periods of negative peace.

Galtung's perspective introduces the idea that although negative peace is a preferable alternative to the violence of war, it lacks the capacity to achieve genuine peace. The absence of positive peace, which involves addressing root causes, fostering reconciliation, and promoting societal well-being, implies that negative peace may not lead to a comprehensive and enduring resolution of conflicts.

Negative Peace (Inner world)

Cultivating inner negative peace, which involves addressing internal conflicts and attaining a state of inner calm, is crucial in the contexts of individual conflict resolution, inner personal harmony, and family conflict avoidance for various reasons:

Facilitating Effective Communication and Resolution: In individual conflict resolution, possessing inner negative peace empowers individuals to approach disagreements with a clear and composed mindset. This mental state facilitates effective communication, active listening, and the ability to find compromises without resorting to aggression. Inner peace is instrumental in fostering a constructive conflict resolution process.

Enhancing Emotional Well-being and Personal Harmony: In the pursuit of inner personal harmony, the development of inner negative peace through practices like meditation and mindfulness aids individuals in managing their emotions. This emotional stability contributes to reduced stress,

improved self-regulation, and an overall sense of well-being. Inner peace forms the basis for personal harmony and a well-balanced emotional state.

Contributing to Healthy Family Dynamics: In the context of family conflict avoidance, inner negative peace assumes a pivotal role. Family members who nurture inner peace are more likely to handle disagreements calmly, steering clear of unnecessary confrontations. By practicing open communication and seeking compromise, individuals within the family actively work towards maintaining a peaceful and harmonious domestic environment. Achieving inner negative peace is imperative as it serves as a catalyst for effective communication, emotional well-being, and the promotion of positive interpersonal dynamics. It provides the internal strength necessary to navigate conflicts, contribute to personal harmony, and foster a tranquil atmosphere within the family.

Negative Peace (Inner world)

Negative peace, viewed externally, encompasses various situations where measures are taken to halt hostilities without necessarily addressing the fundamental causes of conflicts. Here are different examples:

Ceasefires in Interstate Conflict:

Definition: Temporary halting of hostilities between nations without resolving the underlying causes of the conflict.

Example: Two warring nations agree to a ceasefire, putting a temporary end to military operations but without a comprehensive resolution of political or territorial disputes.

Border Conflict Management:

Definition: Implementing measures to prevent violence or escalation of disputes over borders or territories.

Example: Neighboring countries establish protocols and engage in diplomatic efforts to manage border issues, aiming to prevent violent confrontations.

Community Mediation:

Definition: Resolving disputes within a community through dialogue and mediation to prevent them from escalating into violence.

Example: Community leaders or mediators facilitate discussions to address local conflicts and tensions, aiming to avoid physical confrontations.

Ceasefire Negotiators:

Role: Diplomats and negotiators involved in brokering ceasefires between conflicting parties.

Focus: Primarily aimed at stopping immediate violence and creating a period of calm, reflecting a state of negative peace.

Peacekeepers:

Role: United Nations peacekeeping missions and international peacekeeping forces.

Focus: Aimed at maintaining or restoring peace by separating conflicting parties, with a primary goal of preventing direct violence rather than addressing deeper societal issues.

Security and Military Officials:

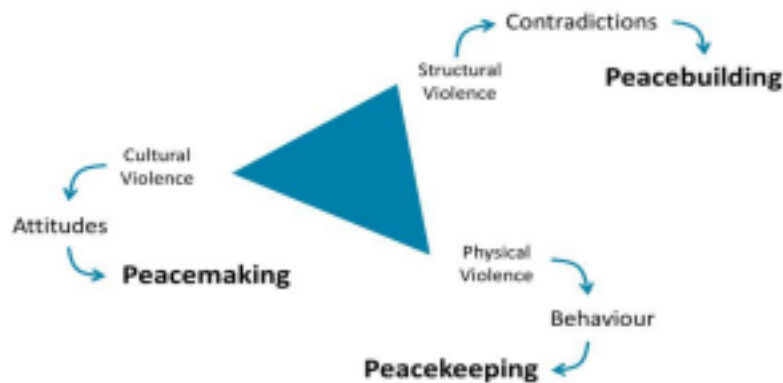
Role: Military and security officials in certain contexts.

Focus: Advocating for negative peace as a means of restoring order and preventing active conflict. Their primary concern is often to establish stability and security without necessarily delving into the

root causes of the conflict.

Negative peace, when viewed externally, involves various strategies and interventions to halt violence temporarily, with a primary emphasis on immediate stability rather than addressing the deeper issues that fuel conflicts

Approaches to Peace



The three approaches to peace are often distinguished by their objectives and methods

Peacekeeping:

Peacekeeping is a method employed to maintain or restore peace in areas affected by conflict or potential conflict. It involves the deployment of a neutral third-party military or civilian force to monitor and separate conflicting parties, supervise ceasefires, and support the implementation of peace agreements. The primary objective of peacekeeping is to create a stable and secure environment by preventing the resumption of hostilities and facilitating the transition to a sustainable peace.

Peacemaking:

Peacemaking involves diplomatic efforts and negotiations aimed at bringing conflicting parties to the negotiation table and facilitating the resolution of the underlying issues that caused the conflict. The objective of peacemaking is to address the root causes of the conflict, find common ground among opposing parties, and broker agreements or treaties that lead to a cessation of hostilities.

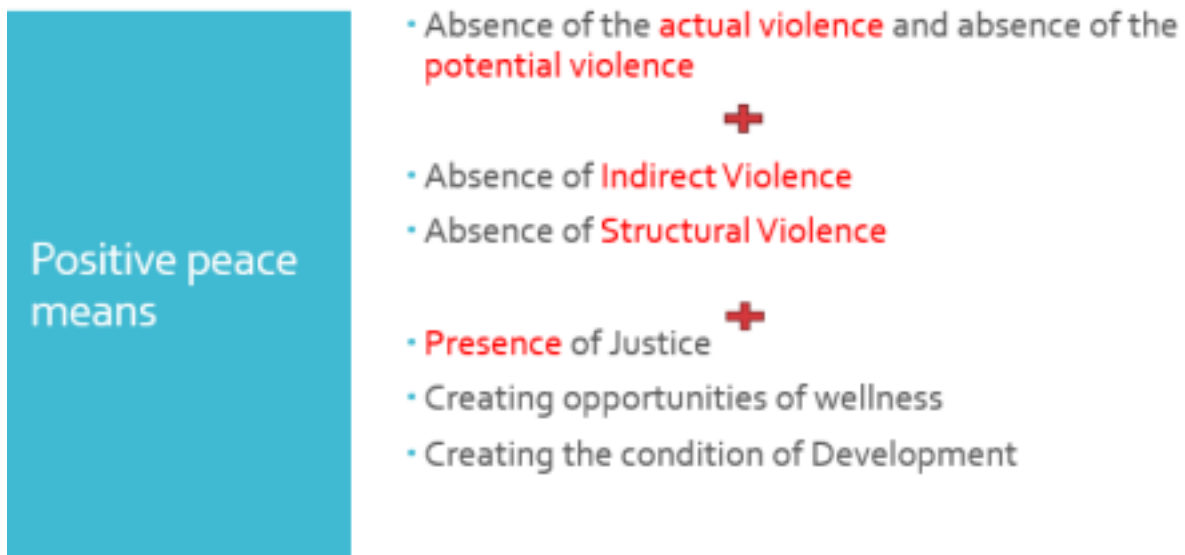
Peacebuilding:

Peacebuilding is a comprehensive, long-term process that focuses on addressing the underlying structural and societal issues that contribute to conflict. It involves initiatives to strengthen governance, promote economic development, foster social cohesion, and establish institutions that support a sustainable peace. The goal of peacebuilding is to create the conditions for lasting peace by addressing the root causes of conflict and building a resilient and inclusive society.



Peacekeeping involves the immediate intervention to prevent violence, peacemaking focuses on diplomatic efforts to resolve conflicts, and peacebuilding is a long-term process that addresses the root causes of conflict to establish a foundation for enduring peace.

Positive Peace



Positive peace signifies a state marked by the nonexistence of both actual and potential violence, along with the absence of indirect and structural violence. It surpasses simply lacking conflict and violence, embracing the inclusion of numerous positive elements:

Absence of Indirect Violence: Positive peace involves not just the absence of direct physical violence but also the elimination of indirect forms of harm or aggression. This encompasses addressing issues like discrimination, social inequalities, and other non physical forms of harm.

Absence of Structural Violence: The objective of positive peace is to eliminate structural violence, encompassing systemic injustices and inequalities ingrained in social, economic, and political structures. Achieving positive peace necessitates addressing and dismantling these foundational structural issues.

Presence of Justice: Positive peace entails establishing and promoting justice within societal structures. This includes fair and equitable legal systems, social

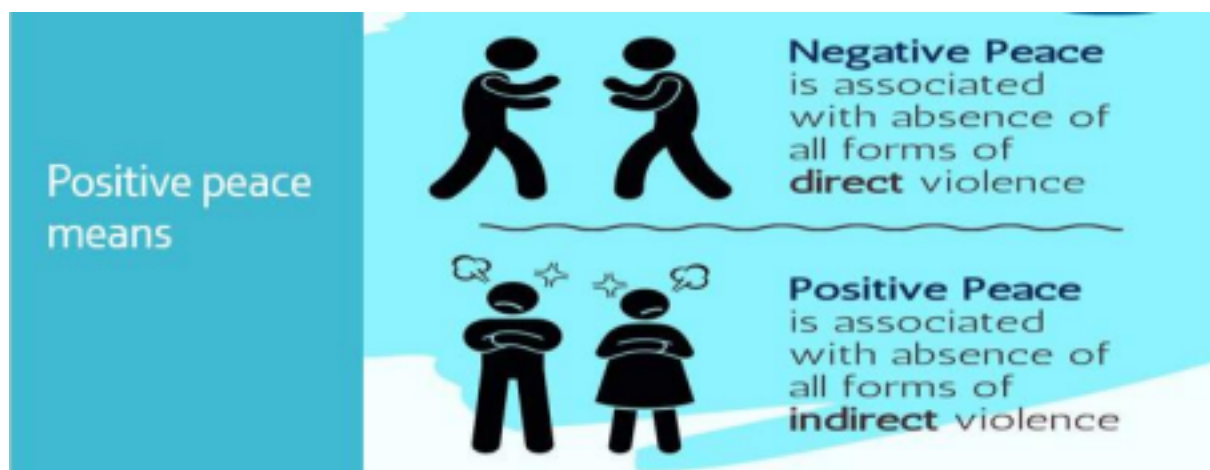
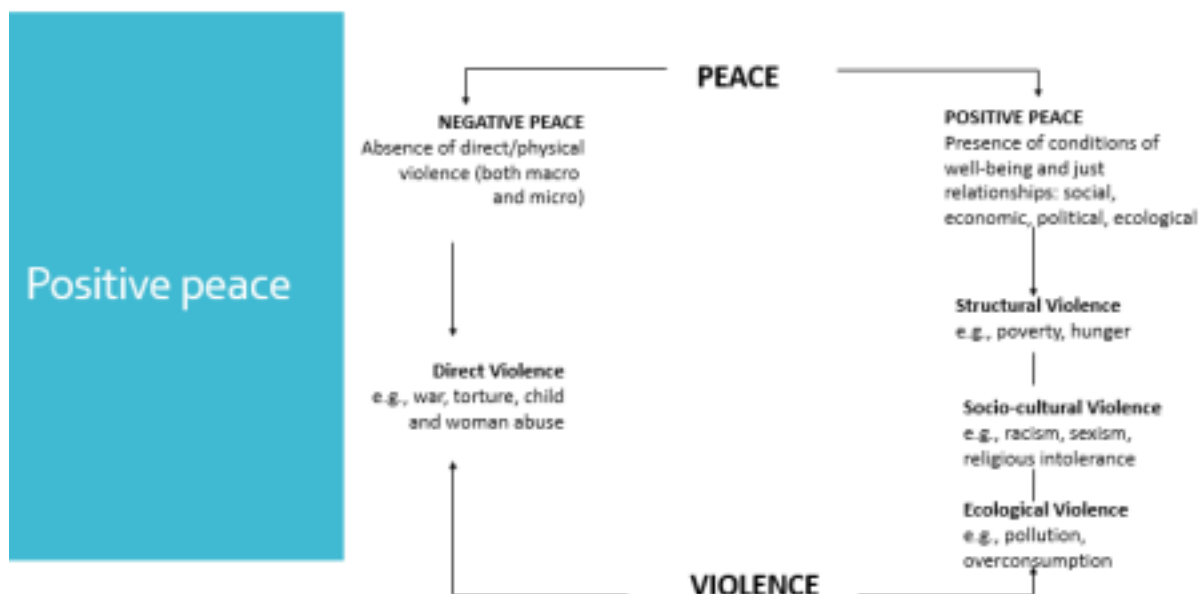
justice, and safeguarding human rights for all individuals.

Creating Opportunities for Wellness: Beyond merely lacking violence, positive peace concentrates on establishing conditions that enhance the overall well-being of individuals and communities. This involves fostering mental and physical health, ensuring access to healthcare, and promoting a sense of security.

Creating the Conditions for Development: Positive peace underscores the importance of conditions supporting sustainable development. This encompasses addressing economic disparities, fostering education, and creating opportunities for social and economic progress.

In essence, positive peace is a comprehensive concept extending beyond the absence of conflict. It involves a society's proactive efforts to tackle underlying issues, advocate for justice, and establish conditions contributing to the overall well-being and development of its members.

Why Positive Peace



Positive peace actively works to eliminate direct, structural, and cultural violence using a thorough and forward-thinking approach. Here's a simplified version:

Ending Direct Violence:

Preventing Conflicts: Positive peace targets the root causes of disputes to prevent direct violence. It emphasizes talking things out, diplomatic efforts, and mediation to resolve issues before they turn into violence.

Social Justice Promotion: By championing social justice, positive peace tackles inequalities that often trigger direct violence. Its goal is to create a society where everyone has equal rights and opportunities.

Building Communities: Positive peace encourages building supportive and connected communities. This sense of togetherness helps prevent interpersonal violence.

Ending Structural Violence:

Promoting Economic Development: Positive peace focuses on sustainable economic development to reduce structural inequalities. Addressing problems like poverty and unequal resource distribution helps dismantle the conditions leading to violence.

Reforming Institutions: Positive peace calls for the overhaul of institutions to ensure fairness and equal representation. This includes legal systems, education, and governance, eradicating discriminatory practices.

Empowering through Education: By empowering marginalized groups and providing education, positive peace aims to break down barriers contributing to structural violence. Education fosters understanding and tolerance, creating a fairer society.

Ending Cultural Violence:

Celebrating Diversity: Positive peace supports celebrating diversity and including different cultures. By fostering understanding and respect, it fights against cultural violence rooted in discrimination.

Encouraging Cultural Exchange: Positive peace promotes programs facilitating dialogue and appreciation of diverse perspectives. These initiatives break down stereotypes and prejudices contributing to cultural violence.

Promoting Tolerance: Through education and awareness, positive peace encourages tolerance and acceptance of various cultural backgrounds. This helps counter cultural violence by creating an atmosphere of respect and understanding.

Types of Violence



Peace science explores these three key conceptualizations: the absence of violence, a state of harmony, and the capacity to handle conflicts non-violently. Each perspective offers valuable insights into understanding and promoting peace in various contexts.

"Peace as the negation of violence" embodies a perspective that defines peace through the absence or reduction of diverse forms of violence in social interactions. The concept recognizes the relative nature of peace, understanding that violence manifests in various

forms and social contexts. For instance, a ceasefire in armed conflict signifies one type of peace, while the reduction of animosity between individuals or within society represents another. This conceptualization underscores a dynamic relationship between peace and violence, positing that peace naturally grows as instances of violence diminish, whether in armed conflicts or interpersonal relationships. Moreover, it advocates for an inclusive understanding of violence, encompassing physical, emotional, and societal dimensions. Recognizing this complexity, the concept emphasizes the importance of addressing diverse manifestations of violence to achieve genuine and comprehensive peace

What is Violence:

Violence, as defined by peace researcher Johan Galtung, who is recognized as the father of peace science, is considered the opposite of peace. Drawing inspiration from the field of medicine for conceptualization, Galtung likens violence to disease in comparison to health. In his framework, he asserts that war is not the antithesis of peace; rather, violence, akin to disease opposing health, serves as its opposite. Galtung's definition emphasizes the diverse nature of violence, drawing a parallel to the multitude of diseases that exist. This perspective suggests that, just as various illnesses manifest in distinct ways, different forms of violence can emerge across various contexts, underlining the need for a nuanced understanding when addressing and preventing violence in the pursuit of peace.

Why to learn Violence?

Learning about violence is crucial in today's context, especially for children who are often surrounded by it. The reasons to understand and address violence include:

Awareness and Prevention:

Learning about violence raises awareness of its presence in various forms. Awareness is the first step toward prevention, helping children recognize and avoid potentially harmful situations.

Empowerment:

Education about violence empowers children to make informed choices. Understanding the consequences of aggressive behavior, both as victims and potential aggressors, equips them with the tools to navigate conflicts more effectively.

Media Literacy:

Given the influence of media, particularly television and the internet, on children, learning about violence enhances media literacy. It enables them to critically analyze and discern between fictional portrayals and real-life implications.

Critical Thinking:

Exposure to violent content in computer games or witnessing family fights can shape children's thinking. Learning about violence encourages critical thinking, allowing them to question, analyze, and form independent perspectives on aggression.

Bullying Prevention:

Many children experience bullying, whether physically or mentally. Learning about violence provides strategies to recognize, report, and prevent bullying, fostering a safer and more inclusive school environment.

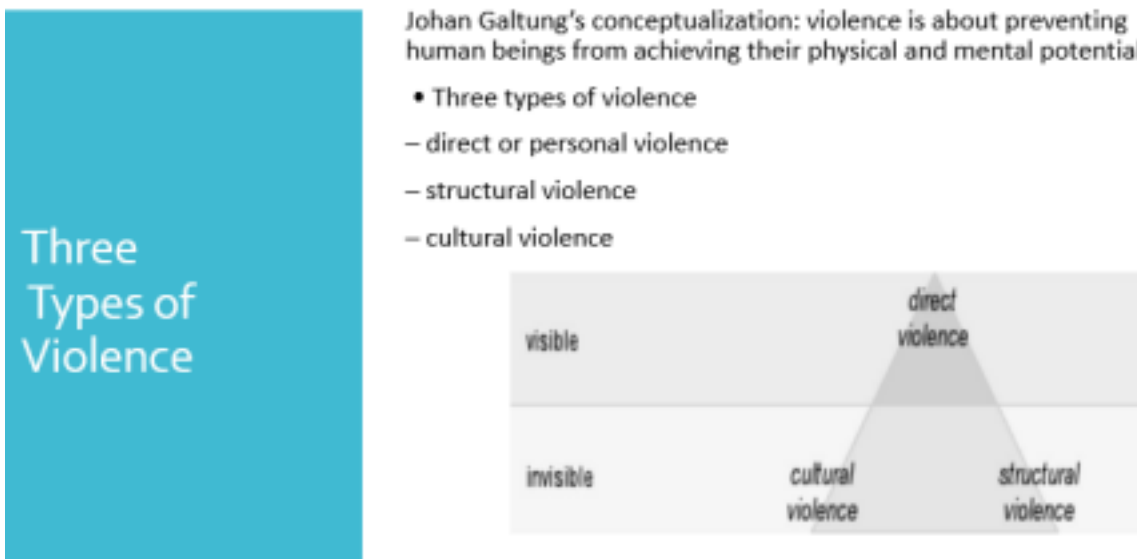
Social and Emotional Development:

Addressing violence contributes to the social and emotional development of children. They learn empathy, conflict resolution, and effective communication, promoting healthier interpersonal relationships.

Crisis Management:

Unfortunately, some children witness violence within their families. Education on violence equips them with coping mechanisms and resources to seek help in such situations.

By learning about violence, children can develop the skills and knowledge needed to navigate the complex landscape they may encounter, promoting a safer and more understanding society.



What is direct violence and Why intention is important:

Direct violence is commonly understood as actions that violate basic needs through the intentional use of physical or psychological power. This type of violence encompasses a range of behaviors, from individual acts such as crime, murder, and assault to large-scale violence like wars. It is crucial to differentiate between two aspects related to intentionality in direct violence:

Unintended Consequences:

In some cases, negative consequences may result from actions that were not intended by the perpetrator. For example, a parent shaking a baby forcefully to stop it from crying might not have intended the resulting brain damage. In these situations, harm occurs, but it was not the intended outcome.

Intention without Recognition of Violence:

In other instances, the consequences were indeed intended, but the perpetrators may not recognize their behavior as violent. For instance, the disciplinary use of physical punishment may be intended to cause harm, but in certain educational traditions, it may not be considered as violence.

Understanding the intention behind direct violence is essential for several reasons:

Legal and Ethical Implications: Intent can have significant legal and ethical implications in determining culpability and appropriate consequences for the perpetrator.

Prevention and Intervention Strategies: Recognizing the intentionality behind violent actions helps in developing targeted prevention and intervention strategies to address the root causes of such behavior.

Educational and Awareness Efforts: By understanding the complexities of intention in violence, educational and awareness programs can be designed to promote alternatives and reshape societal norms.

In essence, intentionality adds layers of complexity to the understanding of direct violence, influencing both its perception and the strategies employed to prevent and address it.

Direct and Indirect Violence



Direct Violence:

Definition: Direct violence is the intentional use of physical or psychological force to harm individuals. It's the most immediate and recognizable form of violence.

Characteristics:

Immediacy: The harm is immediate and visible, often resulting from intentional

actions. **Visibility:** It can be observed directly, and the consequences are apparent.

Scope: Direct violence can occur at individual levels, such as interpersonal conflicts, or on a larger scale, including armed conflicts and wars.

Examples: Physical assault, homicide, verbal abuse, bullying, and acts of war are instances of direct violence.

Indirect Violence:

Definition: Indirect violence refers to harm resulting from systemic, societal, or structural factors. It's not necessarily the outcome of direct, intentional actions but is embedded in broader circumstances.

Characteristics:

Indirectness: The harm often doesn't result immediately from intentional actions but arises from underlying structures or conditions.

Systemic: Indirect violence is systemic and can be perpetuated by societal norms, policies, or economic structures.

Consequences: It can manifest as unequal access to resources, discrimination, or limited opportunities, impacting individuals or communities.

Examples: Discriminatory policies, economic disparities, unequal access to education or healthcare, and systemic inequalities are instances of indirect violence.

Direct and Indirect Violence Differences:

Causation:

Direct violence: Results from intentional actions.

Indirect violence: Arises from systemic or structural factors, not necessarily intentional actions.

Immediacy:

Direct violence: Immediate and visible consequences.

Indirect violence: Indirect and often delayed consequences.

Observability:

Direct violence: Observable and apparent.

Indirect violence: Indirect and may not be immediately noticeable.

Scale:

Direct violence: Can occur at individual or collective levels.

Indirect violence: Systemic and can affect larger societal structures.

Understanding these differences is vital for developing effective strategies to prevent and address both forms of violence.

Structural Violence

What is Structure?

Status:

A socially defined position within a group or society, encompassing one or more roles.

Components: Involves the position an individual holds in a social system based on factors like age, sex, qualifications, economic power, and education.

Rights and Duties:

The entitlements and responsibilities associated with a particular status.

Explanation: Individuals occupying a specific status have inherent rights and corresponding duties within a social structure.

Role:

The expected behavior associated with someone occupying a particular status.

Explanation: Each status comes with a set of roles, outlining the behaviors and expectations linked to that social position.

In essence, the term "structure" in this context refers to the organized framework of social positions (statuses), their associated rights and duties, and the expected behaviors (roles) that individuals fulfill within a group or society.

What is Social Structure?

Social structure refers to the organized patterns of social relationships, institutions, statuses, and roles that collectively form the framework of a society or a group. It establishes the arrangement of individuals within a community, outlining their positions, interactions, and the expectations associated with those positions.

What is Structural Violence?

The concept of 'structural violence,' introduced by Johan Galtung in his 1969 essay "Violence, Peace, and Peace Research," refers to a form of societal harm or injustice that is embedded in the structures and institutions of a society. Unlike direct violence, which involves explicit acts of harm or aggression, structural violence operates more subtly through systemic and institutional mechanisms, resulting in unequal access to resources, opportunities, and basic needs.

Structural violence is injustice and exploitation built into a social system that generates wealth for the few and poverty for the many, stunting everyone's ability to develop their full humanity.

By privileging some classes, ethnicities, genders, and nationalities over others, it institutionalizes unequal opportunities for education, resources, and respect.

Structural violence forms the very basis of capitalism, patriarchy, and any dominator system (Hathaway, 2013)

Why Study Structural Violence?

Studying structural violence is a crucial component in the pursuit of sustainable peace and conflict resolution. This is underscored by several key factors. Firstly, understanding structural violence unveils the root causes of conflicts, revealing deep-seated inequalities ingrained in social, economic, and political structures. This knowledge is instrumental in formulating effective and enduring solutions.

Secondly, awareness of structural violence enables targeted interventions, steering efforts away from merely addressing conflict symptoms toward resolving underlying systemic issues. This approach promotes the development of more sustainable peacebuilding strategies.

Thirdly, the identification of structural violence empowers individuals and groups to advocate for social justice. By challenging discriminatory structures, communities actively contribute to creating fair and inclusive societies, fostering long-term peace. Moreover, the ability to recognize structural violence aids in conflict prevention. Early mitigation of systemic issues helps societies create stable environments, reducing the conditions that give rise to violence. Furthermore, policymakers armed with insights into structural violence can formulate equitable policies that address disparities and promote equality, aligning governance structures with the goal of peace. The study of structural violence also facilitates community empowerment, as affected communities gain awareness and actively engage in advocating for their rights, fostering positive change.

Lastly, understanding the humanitarian impact of structural violence allows organizations to tailor interventions, providing more effective assistance to those in need. Overall, addressing structural violence is indispensable for achieving long-term stability and building the foundation for enduring peace.

Characteristic of Structural violence

Structural violence exhibits distinct features that differentiate it from direct forms of violence, contributing to its unique nature and impact on individuals and communities:

1. Indirect Nature:

Structural violence represents a form of indirect harm, where the inflicted damage does not result from immediate, intentional actions but is instead deeply rooted in broader systemic conditions.

2. Depersonalized Perpetrator:

Unlike direct violence, structural violence lacks a clearly identifiable perpetrator. Pinpointing specific individuals responsible for the harm becomes challenging as it is woven into the fabric of systemic structures.

3. Inherent in Power Structures:

Structural violence is ingrained within the structures of power in a society. It permeates social, economic, and political systems, making it pervasive and resistant to easy eradication.

4. Unequal Access to Opportunities:

A crucial characteristic of structural violence is the uneven distribution of opportunities. This disparity extends across various aspects of life, such as education, healthcare, and employment, creating systemic disadvantages for specific groups.

5. Invisibility and Normalization:

Operating covertly, structural violence becomes normalized and routinized within societal structures. It seamlessly integrates into everyday life, posing challenges for individuals to recognize and confront the deeply embedded injustices.

Understanding these features is vital for the identification and mitigation of structural violence, necessitating focused efforts to dismantle systemic inequalities and foster a society that is more just and equitable.

Structural violence takes on various manifestations deeply ingrained in societal frameworks. Below is a concise overview of structural violence in specific categories:

Forms of Structural Violence

Caste:

Structural violence rooted in caste involves the systemic discrimination and oppression of individuals based on their social caste. This inequality is deeply embedded in social, economic, and political structures, perpetuating disparities and constraining opportunities for specific caste groups.

Class:

Class-based structural violence pertains to inequities in opportunities, resources, and privileges linked to socioeconomic class. Systemic disadvantages for individuals in lower socioeconomic classes arise from the unequal distribution of wealth, education, and

employment opportunities.

Gender:

Structural violence tied to gender encompasses systemic inequalities and discrimination faced by individuals based on their gender identity. Unequal access to education, employment, healthcare, and the perpetuation of gender norms marginalize specific genders.

Racism:

Racism as structural violence entails systemic discrimination and prejudice rooted in race or ethnicity. Deeply ingrained in social institutions, racism leads to disparities in education, employment, healthcare, and overall opportunities for marginalized racial or ethnic groups.

Hunger:

Structural violence related to hunger is discernible in the uneven distribution of resources, including access to food. Factors such as socioeconomic conditions, political policies, and systemic inequalities contribute to food insecurity and hunger in certain populations.

Poverty:

Poverty as structural violence refers to the systematic disadvantages faced by individuals and communities due to economic inequalities. Limited access to education, healthcare, and job opportunities are common expressions of poverty as a form of structural violence.

Recognizing these forms of structural violence is imperative for crafting precise interventions that disassemble systemic injustices and foster a more just and inclusive society.

Cultural Violence



Impact of Cultural Violence:

The influence of cultural violence, as suggested by Galtung, is profound and diverse. Primarily, it plays a crucial role in reshaping the ethical foundations of societies, shaping their interpretation of structural or direct violent acts. Galtung argues that cultural violence serves as a catalyst in altering the ethical character of a society, essentially normalizing or justifying actions that might be considered morally objectionable in a different context.

Much like structural violence, cultural violence operates covertly, integrating deeply into societal norms and values. This hidden nature arises from its seamless assimilation into the

cultural framework, making it difficult for individuals to identify and question these ingrained biases and justifications. In particular, cultural violence perpetuates biased ideologies such as racism, sexism, and other forms of prejudice. These ideologies function as tools to rationalize violent acts, providing a distorted moral structure that legitimizes or justifies harmful actions against specific groups or individuals.

Essentially, the impact of cultural violence surpasses explicit acts of harm, influencing the collective conscience of a society and molding its acceptance or endorsement of violence as a normalized or justified occurrence.



Studying cultural violence is crucial based on the provided text for several significant reasons:

Legitimization of Violence: Excluding violence and its human consequences from education contributes to legitimizing it. Understanding the causes of violence is essential for addressing and preventing it. Therefore, studying cultural violence helps counter its normalization and raises awareness about its detrimental impacts.

Understanding Root Causes: The text suggests that preventing the study of violence and its causes is a form of cultural violence. By studying cultural violence, individuals gain insights into the root causes and underlying factors that contribute to violence. This understanding is fundamental to developing effective strategies for prevention and intervention.

Promoting Free Thought: The text highlights that when people cannot question or think freely without fear, it becomes challenging for them to be objective and stand against injustices. Studying cultural violence facilitates an environment where individuals can critically analyze societal norms, values, and biases, fostering free thought and empowering them to challenge cultural elements that perpetuate violence.

Studying cultural violence is essential for dismantling its influence, understanding its root causes, and promoting an environment where individuals can think freely and objectively stand against injustices.

Cultural violence is perpetuated through various tools ingrained in societal structures, each playing a distinct role:

Tools of cultural violence

1. Cultural Norms:

Cultural norms, representing prevalent societal beliefs, shape acceptable behavior. When

these norms endorse discrimination, they normalize prejudiced attitudes and actions, contributing to a culture of inequality.

2. Stereotypes and Prejudices:

Fixed and oversimplified ideas about certain groups, stereotypes and prejudices foster biased perceptions and discriminatory behavior. They act as mental shortcuts, dehumanizing individuals based on characteristics and perpetuating cultural violence.

3. Racist or Sexist Language:

Language, a powerful tool, can reinforce or challenge cultural norms. The use of racist or sexist language reflects and reinforces biased beliefs, contributing to the persistence of discriminatory attitudes within a culture.

4. Language-Based Discrimination:

Targeting individuals based on language, this form of discrimination reinforces social hierarchies and power imbalances. It leads to exclusionary practices, perpetuating cultural violence.

Recognizing and addressing these tools is crucial in challenging and dismantling cultural violence, fostering a more equitable and inclusive society.

Relationship between Cultural Violence & Structural Violence

The connection between cultural violence and structural violence is complex and intertwined, with several key aspects:

1. Reinforcement Mechanism:

Cultural violence can strengthen and legitimize structural violence. Biased cultural beliefs may be used to justify unfair policies and practices in societal institutions, creating a loop that supports discrimination.

Example: When cultural narratives perpetuate stereotypes about a particular group, institutions may use these stereotypes to justify discriminatory practices against that group.

2. Normalization of Inequality:

Cultural violence contributes to making discriminatory beliefs and practices seem normal. This normalization supports and justifies structural violence by embedding biased attitudes into societal norms.

Example: If cultural norms accept gender-based discrimination, it may normalize unequal treatment of women in various social and institutional settings.

3. Resistance and Change:

Changes in cultural norms and attitudes can challenge structural violence. Conversely, changes in structural policies can influence cultural perceptions over time, showing how they interact and influence each other.

Example: Increased awareness about racial equality in society may lead to changes in laws and policies, challenging structural racism.

4. Complex Interaction:

Cultural and structural violence interact dynamically. Biased cultural beliefs may shape structures that perpetuate harm, while structural violence reinforces cultural norms, creating a complex interplay.

Example: Discriminatory cultural beliefs about ethnic groups may influence housing policies that contribute to residential segregation.

5. Intersectionality:

Cultural and structural violence intersect with other forms of violence, such as direct violence. This intersectionality creates intricate webs of oppression, where different types of violence reinforce each other.

Example: Discrimination based on both race and socioeconomic status may lead to disparities in access to education, health, and job opportunities, illustrating the interconnectedness of cultural and structural violence

VEDAS

PART A: History of Vedas

Introduction

The classical Indian tradition and Hinduism are rooted in the ancient scriptures called the Vedas. The Sāṅskrit root of the Veda is 'vid' which means knowledge. They are the earliest scriptural texts handed down to the generations of humankind containing the divine truths. The Vedas are said to be apocryphal (apauruṣeya) अपौरुषेय for no human agency is involved in their creation. The Vedas are also known as Shruti (literally meaning hearing) for they belong to oral tradition. The great sages and seers preserved them in their memory and transmitted the Vedic knowledge only to those who deserved to receive them. Thus there were no written compilations in the beginning. But there arose a need to compile them in a written form. This task was undertaken by the sage named Krishna dwaipayana Vyasa. He codified the single Vedic compendium into four Vedas: - Rig, Yajur, Sama and Atharva. This is the reason why he is also called Veda Vyasa. In memory of this great sage the Hindus celebrate Guru Purnima. On his birth day, however, it is stated in the Vishnu Purana that Vyāsa was assisted by four of his disciples in the process of the compilation of the Vedas. Paila assisted him to compile Rigveda, Vaisampayana, the Yajurveda, Jaimini, the Samaveda, and Sumantu, the Atharvaveda.



The Structure of the Vedas

Each Veda is divided into two parts: karma kanda and jnyan kanda. The former deals with

the Samhitas (collections of Mantras) and the Brahmanas as and the latter with the Āranyakas and the Upanishads. In other words, this classification is needed to show the distinction between action and knowledge. Those who are interested in material gains follow the former portion and those who are interested in acquiring knowledge follow the latter. Mantras are hymns addressed to eulogize gods or goddesses for some material favor. The collection of such Mantras is called Samhita. There are four **Samhitas**: Rig, Yajur, Sama, and Atharva. These Samhitas are compiled for the smooth and unhindered performance of the Vedic rituals or sacrifices (yajnya). But yajnya always means a sacrificial celebration. A Vedic sacrifice requires four chief priests. They are: Hota, one who recites hymns in praise of gods and goddesses to invoke their presence and participation in the yajnya, Udgātā, one who sings the hymns in sweet and appealing musical tones to please the gods and goddesses, Adhvaryu, one who performs the yajnya in accordance with the strict ritualistic code and gives offerings to the gods, and Brahma, one who supervises the entire proceedings of the yajnya as he is well-versed in all the four Vedas. These Vedic sacrifices are intended to satisfy the needs of the above mentioned four priests who represent the four Samhitas respectively. Sometimes, we also come across the view that originally the Vedas were only three in number (Veda - trayi). But it is believed that the Atharvaveda was added to the list of three later on and it mainly deals with the secular aspects of human life. It is also held in traditional Hindu texts that Rig means verse, Sama means songs, and Yajuh means prose passage. Thus Samhita or Mantra portion of the Veda consists of hymnology addressed to the various gods and goddesses. Rishis Samhita is the oldest and the most important of all the Samhitas. The Vedic Rishis are not the authors of the Vedas, but only the seers of the Mantras. The Brahman, unlike Mantras, is in prose. They elaborate the complicated ritualism of the Vedas by emphasizing on the rules and regulations laid down for the performance of yajnya. The expression 'Brahman' is originally derived from the word 'Brahman' which means a prayer. There is very little philosophy in these portions. The appendages to these Brahmanas are called Aranyakas. They are called so because they are composed in the forests amidst calmness. These texts are mark of transition from ritualistic portion of the Vedas to their knowledge (philosophical) portion. Here in this portion we find mystic interpretation of the Vedic sacrifices. The concluding portion of the Vedas is called Upanishads. They are highly philosophical in their purport and regarded as the cream of the Vedic philosophy. This is the reason why Upanishad is called 'Vedanta'.

Philosophy in the Vedas

Hardly one finds any philosophical thought in the preUpanishadic thought. But one cannot ignore the seeds of the important philosophical truths found there. There is a gradual development of philosophical thought from the Mantras to the Brahmanas to the Aranyakas to the Upanishad.

There is a natural transition from naturalistic and anthropomorphic polytheism through transcendent monotheism to immanent monism in the preUpanishadic thought. The personified natural forces changed into real gods and later on became mere forms of mere forms of one personal and transcendental God, who is the custodian of 'Cosmic and Moral order'. This personal and transcendental God Himself passed into immanent Purusha. Later on the Upanishads developed this immanent and transcendent Purusha into all-pervading Brahman/Atman. The Mantra portion represents the religion of 'Nature' of the poets, the Brahman a portion ritualism and the religion of 'Law' of the priests, the Upanishadic portion the religion of 'Spirit' of the philosophers. The western interpretation of the Vedas does not go well with the spirit of the Vedas. According to such interpretations, the Vedic seers were inspired by the primitive natural forces. But it is the other way round. The Vedas are

authorless and eternal. The Vedic seers with their intellect and spiritual powers came face to face with the Reality and this mystic experience or direct intuitive spiritual insight overflowed in the literature as the Vedic hymns. The important feature of the Vedic hymns is the same spiritual monism, the same immanent conception of the identity-in-difference that which ultimately transcends

itself. Such a view is poetically explained in the Upanishad. All the gods are the manifestation of the same supreme God or principle. When gods are praised, in fact, it is the supreme God who is praised through His manifestations. However, one can only see monism throughout the Vedas.

Some of the descriptions reveal the true nature of the Real. For example, in the Rig-Veda it is mentioned "The One Real, the wise declare as many (*ekam sad vipra bahudha vadanti*)."

Further it is also said "Purusha is all this, all that was, and all that shall be (*Purusha evedam sarvam yad bhutam yachcha bhavyam*)."

In fact, "The same 'Real' is worshipped as Uktha in the Rigveda, as Agni in the Yajuh and as Mahavrata in the Sama." From the above references it is evident that the Vedas always referred to one single monistic principle as the supreme Reality. Although one cannot really distinguish between religion and philosophy in the Rigveda, the kind of questions that one confronts give an impression that both religious and philosophical concerns are embedded in the structuring of the Vedas. The following questions substantiate our view. What makes the wind blow? Why does the monsoon come? Who put the sun, giver of warmth and light, in the heavens? How it is that broad-bosomed earth brings forth these myriad life forms? These questions are highly philosophical although modern science may take credit to answer these questions. But, roughly 6000 years ago, these questions were the concern of philosophers. Further, there are also questions such as: What is beyond the gods? What, if any, is the relationship between actions and their consequences? What knowledge, if any, does man have of himself? Of course the questions How? Why? And with what? It may be appropriate with when applied to human creativity. But, when these questions are addressed to natural activity the natural forces (gods) in their personified form are brought into the picture.

3. Religion in the Vedas. Does one find religion in the Vedas? If at all there is one, it is none other than the Vedic dharma.

The personification of natural forces (gods) to a great extent answers the questions without entering into the world of mystery. The god of fire (Agni) has certain natural powers. Similar is the case with the god of wind (Vayu). Thus gods as natural forces are responsible for any natural activity. Thus vital questions of how and why are answered in terms of who. Then the people sought to control nature by offering prayers, sacrifices, and rituals for their benefit. Therefore, it is not a wonder why one finds so many hymns in the Vedas to propitiate gods and goddesses. Sometimes, it is viewed that not all the seers of the Rigveda intended religion as the way of understanding and controlling nature and humans. This is evident from the following passage from the Rigveda.

Who knows for certain? Who shall here declare it? Whence was it born? And whence came this creation? The gods were born after this world's creation: Then who can know from whence it has arisen? None know when his creation has arisen; and whether He has or has not produced it: He who surveys it in the highest heaven, He only knows, or perhaps even he may know not. The great seers were the seekers of wisdom not just knowledge. They went beyond the gods to the ultimate

Principle that rules even the gods. They came to know through their extraordinary powers that there is an immutable and eternal moral order that regulates the natural phenomena. It is

popularly known as Rita. This is the moral principle that provides order and purpose to the cosmic reality. Nothing takes place in the reality unless otherwise directed by the eternal moral order Rita. Perhaps religion came into the picture only when rituals and sacrifices are performed by humans in order to eulogize the gods for their mundane favors. But the questions how the gods controlled nature and how the humans could influence the gods resulted in a serious theological interpretation. But majority of these explanations are from the Brahmana portion of the Veda which highlight the details of religious worship, although occasionally they crossed the limits of the given answers in order to seek the efficacy of a ritual or sacrifice in terms of the primordial principles.

The following passage from the Satapatha Brahmana reveals it: verily, in the beginning this (universe) was the Brahman. It created the gods; and, having created the gods, it made them ascend these worlds: Agni (this terrestrial world), Vayu the air, and Surya the sky. Then the Brahman itself went up to the sphere beyond. Having gone up to the sphere beyond, it considered, "How can I descend again into these worlds?" It then descended again by means of these two, Form and Name, these (Name and Form) indeed are the two great forces of Brahman; and verily, he who knows these two great forces of Brahman becomes himself a great force. The above passage indicates that there is an attempt to explain the religions in terms of the philosophical. However, both these aspects are promiscuously mixed up with each other. Later on in the Aranyakas one finds a shift from ritualism to free intellectual inquiry into the nature of reality. Although the Aranyakas do not oppose the religious way they brought in meditation in the place of sacrifice. The meditation gradually led to free speculation and contemplation that permeated the Upanishads. One should remember that it is not all that easy to distinguish religion and philosophy in the Vedas. Coming to the hymns of the Rigveda, they are all in praise of the gods.

As stated earlier all these gods are personalities presiding over the diverse forces of nature or their very essence. Therefore, one cannot attribute any special characteristics to them like the Greek gods or the gods found in the Puranic literature. These Vedic gods may be different from those listed in the Purana as for they are the expressions of the powers of nature. Take for instance, the god of fire (Agni). He "lies concealed in the softer wood, as in a chamber, until, called forth by the rubbing in the early morning, he suddenly springs forth in gleaming brightness. The sacrifice takes and puts him on the wood. When the priests pour melted butter upon him, he leaps up crackling and neighing like a horse, he whom men love to see increasing like their own prosperity. Since these natural forces are treated as gods, the view that the Vedic people were polytheistic gained popularity. There is, in fact, neither polytheism nor monotheism rather it is a simple stage of belief. Unlike in the polytheistic faith, the Vedic gods do not preserve their proper places. They do shrink into insignificance or shine as supreme. On a definite occasion a particular god is eulogized as supreme in order to satisfy one's need. However, it is not to be interpreted that all other gods are less important or insignificant for the Vedic gods are not independent of all the rest. In other words, each god is standing out as highest when he comes to the mind of the suppliant. Of the Vedic gods six of them are most important. They are: Varuna, Indra, Agni, Soma, Rudra and Vishnu. The latter two are important because they are developed into full-fledged Gods by their respective sects as supreme Beings.

Varuna was regarded as the highest ethical creation as well as the great celestial Brahmana by the Vedic Hindus. Indra was worshipped as the god of victory being a warrior-king and was invoked very frequently as a god of storm. Agni and Soma were also given importance as terrestrial gods representing fire and plant respectively. Invariably both these gods were

invoked during the rituals.

Agni as the fire consumes the sacrifice and as the priest he presents it to the gods above. In a way he is the mediator between the gods and humans. He is not only a priest who brings gods and humans together, but also the element who binds the three worlds. He is the sun in the heaven, lightening in the storm cloud, and used as fire by humans on the earth. His threefold birth corresponds to the threefold structure of the Universe. Soma is an indispensable plant used in the sacrifice. This plant is yellowish in color and is found in the mountains. The juice of this plant is filtered through a fine cloth. Since the juice is in liquid form it is likened to waters and streams. Soma is the Lord of streams and son of waters. Since the plant is yellow in colour it is likened to the lightening. Indra being the warrior god, he is depicted as manly of men. As a Vedic precursor Indra remained close to humans as their friend, brother, and their father and mother. He is both generous and quick to wrath. His favorites are not the priestly families as often mentioned in the Rigveda but the fighting men. His might is immeasurable and his generosity knows no bounds. If Varuna is the king by divine right, Indra is the king by right of conquest. One can also notice the signs of rivalry between these two gods in the Rigveda. Varuna is the Universal monarch whereas Indra is the monarch of his own making. Varuna abides by the law and truth as their guardian. In other words,

Varuna is the guardian of Ruta (ऋत), the 'cosmic order'. He possesses uncanny power (maya). This is the reason why people must approach him with utmost fear and extreme circumspection. Rudra is another Vedic god who inspires terror. He kills and makes people alive, he wounds and he heals them. In the Vedas it is held that Rudra was not associated with other Vedic gods excepting with Maruts, also called Rudras, who are his sons. But there is another side of Rudra. He is not only the destroyer, but also a great physician with thousand remedies at his disposal. In the Rigveda it is mentioned that his hand is soothing and, healing and cool. His hand takes away all the ailments sent by other gods. Further the Rudra is developed as Rudra-Shiva in Atharvaveda he is given the title 'Pashupati' or the Lord of the cattle. It is in this form the devotees started worshipping him for they saw themselves as Rudra's cattle and the god is the lord of the cattle. Coming to Vishnu, like Shiva, he is a great God of classical Hinduism. Shiva appeared in the form of the Vedic Rudra. But, out of 1,017 hymns found in the Rigveda only six hymns are addressed to Lord Vishnu and three of them he shares with god Indra. From these hymns we come to know that he measures the earth, the sky and the beyond. Mortals can only traverse the first two and Vishnu alone knows the third and the highest. Thus he sets limits to the finite world.

To sum up, the Vedas are the revealed scriptures of the Hindus and they are of not human origin. Philosophy and religion are promiscuously mixed up in the Vedas. They contain eternal truths. They are also known as Shruti for the Vedic wisdom was orally transmitted to the deserving disciples by the great seers and sages. The Vedic gods were the personification of natural forces. The entire universe was controlled by the moral order called Ruta (ऋत). The

Vedic gods Indra, Varuna, Agni, Rudra and Vishnu were worshipped by the ancient Hindus. Thus one finds both religious and philosophical ideas in the Vedas. They may not be conspicuous but one has to look for them in the vast Vedic literature.

In Indian tradition there are fourteen or eighteen Vidyashtanas (abodes of knowledge/ cognition).

Svara or accent:

Sanskrit language can be put under two headings - Vaidika and Laukika. There is Svara or

accent in Sanskrit language. But during the course of time Svara lost its significance in Laukika (secular or non-Vedic) literature. But Svara plays an important role in Vedic literature. Any change of Svara would lead to change of meaning. There are mainly three Svaras, viz. Udātta, Anudātta and Svarita.

दुष्टःशब्दःस्वरतोवर्णतोवा मथियाप्रयुक्तोनतिर्णिह स वाग्वज्रोयजिनं महनस्ति
यरेन्द्रशतुः स्वरतोऽपराधात् ॥

Classification of Vedas:

Veda can be put under four headings - Mantra, Brahmana, Aranyaka and Upanishad. The Mantra portion is called Samhita. Mantras are commending texts of different deities and literally mean - those, which protect if recited with concentration. Brahmanas comment on Mantras and explain the procedure of a rite. Both the above portions are useful for a person during Brahmacharya (celibacy) and Gārhāsthya (married life) - the first two Ashramas (stages of life) and also in the performance of different rites. The Aranyaka portion, which should be recited in a forest, as the name suggests, is useful for a person during the third Ashrama called Vanaprastha (living in a forest). Upanishads are useful during the fourth Ashrama called Samnyasya (giving up all Karmas such as Yaga etc. but still performing the Nityakarmas like Sandhyavandanam and Naimittikakarmas such as death ceremony of parents). One may directly go to Samnyasa from Brahmacharya.

Branches (shakhas) of Vedas:

Rigveda has got 21 branches but only two are available. Yajurveda has 9 branches. It is divided into two - KrishnaYajurveda and Shuklayajurveda. Four branches of KrishnaYajurveda and two branches of Śuklayajurveda are available. Sāmaveda has got 1000 branches of which only three are available. Atharvaveda has got nine branches of which only two are available.

1. Rigveda : 21 Branches
2. Yajurveda: 9 Branches
3. Samveda: 1000 Branches
4. Atharvaveda- 9 Branches (2 Available)



A Brief account of Vedas:

Rigveda:

‘Rik’ literally means a text of praise of a deity. Some Riks make a Sukta, some Suktas make a Maṇḍala. There are ten Maṇḍalas in Rigveda consisting of 1017 Sūktas and the total number of Riks is 10,472. Ayurveda is the Upaveda of Rigveda.

KrishnaYajurveda:

Yajus means ‘vakyam’ (sentence). Since the Yajus are found to be clustered for most of the part, it is called Samhita. The sentences are to be divided with the help of Purvamimamsa. In KṛṣṇayajusSamhita all the three kinds of texts, viz. Mantra (which praises the deity), Arthavāda (sentences of commendation and condemnation) and Brahmana (which explains the procedure) are seen in an amalgamated form and therefore the word ‘Krishn’ (literally ‘black’) is prefixed. Some Riks are supplied by Rigveda; the procedural details of Yāga (sacrifice) are stated in Krishayajurveda, which is also called Taittiriyaśamhita. There are seven Kandas, forty-four Prapāṭhakas (or Adhyayas) and 635 Anuvakas (or Prashnas) in Taittiriyaśamhita. Dhanurveda is the Upaveda of Krishayajurveda.

Shuklayajurveda:

Also called Shuklayajus samhita and it is useful in the performance of Yaga (sacrifice). In this Samhita there are Mantras and Arthavadas. Since the concepts are clear the term ‘Shukla’ (white) is prefixed. Yājnyavalkya was the disciple of Vaiśampāyana and learnt Yajurveda. There was some clash between them and Yajnyavalkya returned the Veda to his Guru, worshipped Aditya (Sun), got the Vidyā and the same is called Shuklayajurveda. Other sages, following the order of Guru, in the form of Tittiri birds took the Vidya, returned by Yajnyavalkya and therefore it is called Taittiriyaśmahita or Krishnayajurveda. Shuklayajurveda has got two versions called Mādhyandinapāṭha and Kāṇvapāṭha but without much difference. Dhanurveda is an Upaveda of Shuklayajurveda.

Samaveda:

Most of the Mantras are borrowed from 8th and 9th Maṇḍalas of Rigveda; ‘Sama’ literally means ‘to sing’. If the Riks are assigned some music they would become Samas.

SamaSamhita is divided into two parts - Purvarchikam and Uttararchikam. A group of Riks is called Arcikam. There are six Prapāṭhakas in Pūrvārcika whereas Uttarārcika has got nine Prapāṭhakas. Gandharvaveda is an Upaveda of SāmaSamhita.

Atharvaveda:

Atharvasamhita is divided into twenty Kandas. There are 736 Suktas and 5918 Mantras in this Samhita (Shaunakashakha). 1200 Mantras of this Samhita are borrowed from Rigveda. In this Samhita we come across a blend of prose and poetry. Atharva is the name of a Ṛṣi. Arthaveda / Arthashastra (polity) is an Upaveda of Atharvaveda.

General Points

‘Trayi’ is a term that is often used to refer to the combine of Rigveda, Yajurveda and Sāmaveda. In a Yāga, Rigveda is represented by Hota. Sāmaveda by Udgātā, Yajurveda by Adhvaryu and Atharvaveda by Brahma. In fact, Brahma, being the supervisor of Yaga, should know all the four Vedas. The first three Vedas produce only half of the Yaga that is in the form of speech whereas the rest in the form of mind is by Atharvaveda. Puruṣasūktam that is there in all five Vedas (Rigveda, KrishnaYajurveda, Shuklayajurveda, Samaveda and Atharvaveda) clearly states that all the four Vedas were available at a single point of time - ṛcassāmāni jajnire chandamasi jajnire tasmāt yajustasmādajāyata. There are certain branches of Vedas named after Rishis - Kathaka, Kalapaka, Vashishtha etc. by which some scholars got confused and said that those Śākhās were authored by the respective sages. But the fact is that they are propagators / specialists of those Mantras and are called Mantradraṣṭāraḥ / Mantrakṛtāḥ etc. As has already been stated in the Introduction, Vedas are Apaurusheya (not written by human beings). They have emanated from Brahman.

At the end of every Pralaya (the great destruction) the Vedas also disappear. Then, after the new creation has started, the Rishis (sages) perform Tapas (an ascetic life) and perceive the Mantras and therefore the same are named after them - Vasishtham Sama etc. We come across dozens of such Rishis across all the Vedasamhitas. The Mantras in Samhitas are assigned to different deities such as Agni, Indra, Vishnu, Rudra, Varuṇa, Surya, Vayu, Soma, Brihaspati, Pṛthvī, Gāyatrī etc. Vedas are the origin of different Vedangas, Darshanas and Upavedas etc. Shruti, Anusarava, Trayi, Ammaya, Samamnaya, Chandas, Svādhyāya, Agama and Nigama are synonyms of Veda. Caraṇam is a name of Vedic text before it was divided into branches. Pratishakhyas is the name of Vedic grammar and there are five Pratishakhyas for five Vedas. Brihad devata is a treatise that explains the details of each Mantra and presently it is available for Rigveda only.

Summary

Among the 14/18 Vidhyashtanas, Vedas occupy the first place and out of 1130 branches only 12/13 are available. Vedas are Apauruseya and are the original source of all other Vidyas. At the end of each Pralaya all the Vedas disappear and the Rishis, with their Tapas, perceive / hear the Vedic Mantras and propagate them and therefore are called Mantrakrutah. The Mantras / Vedic texts perceived by Rishis are named after them - Kathaka, Kalapaka, Paippalada etc. Samaveda is a musical form of Rigveda. Mantrabrahman part deals with Karma (rite) whereas Upanishad deals with Dnyana.

PART B: Doctrines of Veda

Veda means a mass of knowledge and is considered as the most ancient literature known to humans. Unlike any other literature, the Vedic one is Apaurusheya (non-human), i.e. not authored by human beings. Uninterrupted tradition tells us that Veda had emanated from Brahma at the beginning of Creation. Since Creation repeats, Veda is considered as "anadi" (beginningless) and "ananta" (endless) and as such it is indestructible.

Veda can be divided into two major parts – the first one deals with Karma (rituals) and the second one with Jnana (cognition). A careful survey of Veda leads us to believe that apart from the above two goals, Veda also offers - guidelines to protect the Elements, purification of mind, harmony in the society, personality development etc.

The roots of Dharma can be traced to Veda

Until Vedavyasa, a sage, ventured to divide, there was a single mass of Veda. Rigveda, Yajurveda, Sāmaveda and Atharvaveda have emerged after the division. Originally Rigveda had had 21 branches; Yajurveda, 100 branches; Samaveda, 1000 branches; and Atharvaveda, 9 branches. Presently only 12 branches of all Vedas are available. Rigveda contains Riks (hymns) that praise the deity. Yajurveda consists of Yajus (sentences) that explain the performance of rituals. Samaveda is nothing but Rigveda associated with music (Samagana). Atharvaveda consists of a blend of prose and poetry. Apart from spiritual matters, Atharvaveda deals with matters of mundane importance such as health, polity etc. also.



Dichotomy of Veda

Broadly Veda can be put under two headings – Mantrabhaga and Brahmanabhaga. The term "mantra" literally means, "the one that protects if recited with meditation". Mantras are used in Yajñas (sacrifices and rituals) and other Karmas (rites). Samhita is a synonym of Mantrabhāga. Brāhmaṇas explain the Mantras. Aranyakas and Upanishads are also included in Brahmanas.

The Vedic tradition firmly stands on a base called Dharma, i.e. one can attain Mokṣa (by which the cycle of birth and death is arrested once and for all) only by following Dharma and one should see that both Artha and Kama are associated with Dharma. Dharma leads one to Svarga (heaven) and Moksha, whereas Adharma (non-dharma) would cause Naraka (hell).

Why are these scriptures important?

To learn about any cultural scriptures of that country is important. There is no Author of Vedas but Rishis are seers of Vedas that's why Rishis are not Author but Seers of Vedas. Experience of Rishis is very dynamic. Vedas are books of knowledge of the nature of reality. Veda is a device that provides non-mundane solutions for getting the desired things and averting the undesired ones. It must here be emphasised that on the doctrinal level the Vedas deal both with worldly life and the inner life of the Self. They teach how to conduct ourselves in such a manner as to create Atmic well-being. And their concern is not with the liberation of the individual alone; they speak about the ideals of social life and about the duties of the public. How the Brahmin ought to lead his life and how the king must rule his subjects and what ideals women are to follow: an answer to these-stated in the form of laws-is to be found in these scriptures. The Vedas indeed constitute the apex of our law-books.

Yaga and Yajnya (sacrifice / ritual)

Yaga and Yajnya both the terms are synonyms. They are formed through the verbal root "yaj" (to worship). There are a number of Yagas described in Veda, such as Darśapūrṇamāsa (performed during new moon day and full moon day). One desirous of Svarga (heaven) should perform this Yāga –darśapūrṇamāsābhyāṃ svargakāmo yajeta.

Yajnya means give and take, we can see in Yajnya, Yajman (host of Yajnya) offers his precious belongings for it, because Yajman or vedic people are expressing gratitude through this act, as we have seen in vedic period all deities belong to nature, they are nature god, and nature gives

everyone everything for free and Yajnya is medium by which we can give back to nature and express gratitude and also pray for the continuation of its offerings.

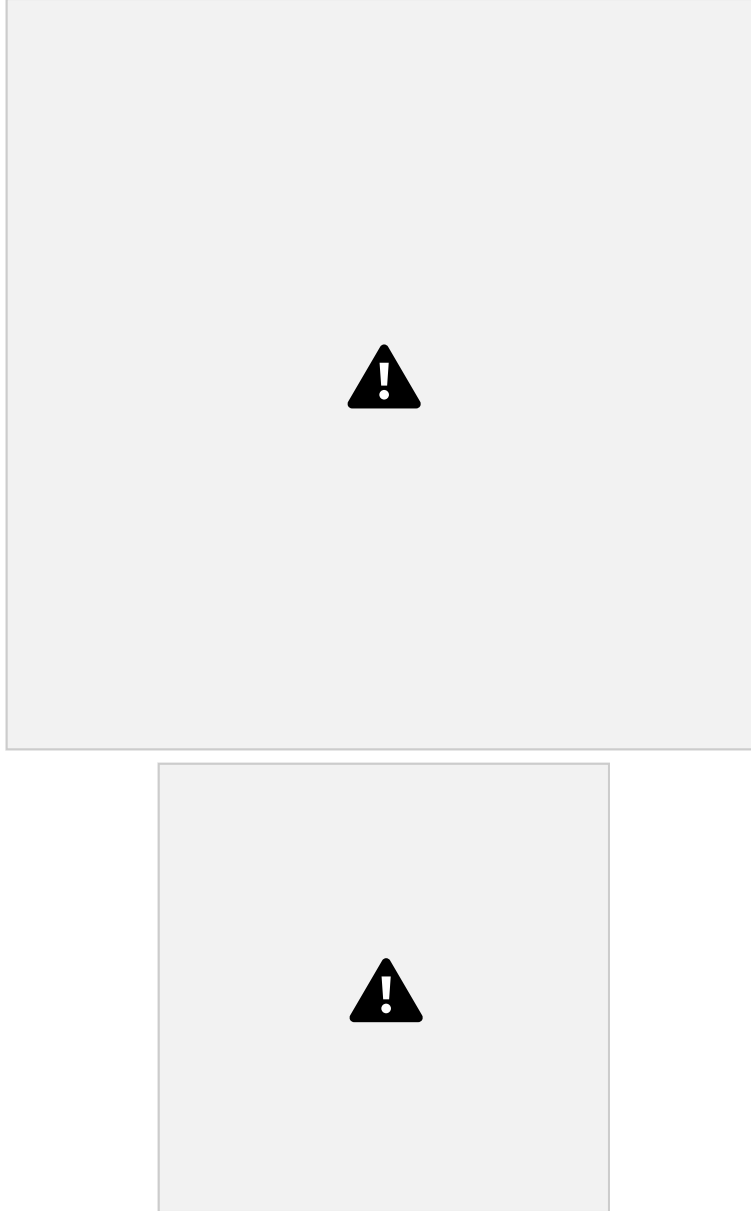
With this Yajnya system we can see that economy, social systems and also science had been developed that time, because to perform Yajnya one needs equipment of Yajnya, priest and other services too, for this Yajman (host) is depend upon all Varnas of society (i.e, for Yajnya equipment Yajman needs Carpenter, for Mantra chanting Yajman needs Priest) and through this vedic economy got developed.

While performing Yajnya one was supposed to follow Muhurt (particular time), for that Vedic people were observing Timings of sun and moon, through this Astronomy got developed.

We can find Pythagoras theorem in Vedic Text. To perform Yajnya rituals, construction of YajnyaKunda (Vedi) is very important and it has particular measurements and through this Geometry had been developed. Like this only other branches of science like biology, botany, and metallurgy had been developed. So Yajnya was crucial and important part of Vedic people.

Vedas are multifaceted and Universal

If we conduct a careful survey of even the available Vedic literature we come across a number of issues concerning Creation, non-pollution of Elements, non-polluted mind, personality development, social unity, treatment of elders, conjugal relationship, polity, economic prosperity etc., which are not directly confined to spiritual life but are essential in maintaining universal peace, health, hygiene, prosperity and unity. Here are some Suktas (chapters of good sayings):



Rigveda 10-191-4

The last Mantra of Rigveda (10-191-4) deals with equality among human beings:

Let the desires of all of us be the same.

Let the hearts of all of us be the same.

Let the thoughts of all of us run on the same rope.

Let all of us unite and become good friends.

समानी व आकू ततः समाना हृदयातन वः। समानमस्तुवो मनो यथा वः

सुसहासतत।। samānī va ākūtiḥ samānā hṛdayāni vaḥ ।

samānamastu vo mano yathā vaḥ susahāsatī ||10-191-4



Outcome of vedas

According to Vedic philosophy human life has a definite purpose. Whilst the final Goal of life is "Moksha", there are three other (intermediary) goals of life. These together are called four objectives or pursuits of life, which are as follows: -

1. DHARMA - Righteousness
2. ARTHA - Acquisition of wealth by proper means and its right use
3. KAMA - Fulfillment of noble desires
4. MOKSHA - Liberation or the final Goal

It is essential to have the proper understanding of these objectives (as also because these terms are highly used in our daily language to mean different things). We shall describe these briefly in the following:-

DHARMA

This is the first and foremost objective or pursuit of life. Dharma is a Sanskrit word and it has no exact equivalent in English language. It has much wider significance than the word 'religion', in its ordinary sense, as currently in vogue in the existing conventional forms. The word DHARMA has been derived from its root Dhri which means 'to uphold', 'to adopt', 'to safeguard', etc. In essence, therefore DHARMA means that which is worthy of being upheld or being practiced. Thus, DHARMA is a comprehensive term which covers an entire range of values.

DHARMA has two factors: (a) Genuine faith and devotion to God, as all noble qualities emanate from God; and (b) Practice of righteousness in ones' life, also called as 10 basic principles of Dharma. The above two factors can be the unifying basis for all conventional religions. Hence, it has also been called as Sanatan (forever) or Manav (human) Dharma.

The ten basic principles of Dharma are the following: -

1. Forbearance:- It is the quality to remain calm and composed in all circumstances.
2. Control of mind: - One should exercise full control over the mind which is always restless and changing.
3. Kshama (Forgiveness):- It is virtue of those who are physically and morally strong. However, it is not desirable to forgive a habitual wrong doer.
4. Non Stealing:- One should not steal or take away or acquire anything which belongs to

others, without paying its proper price and without permission of the rightful owner

5. Shauch (Cleanliness):- One should keep the body, mind and physical environment clean and pure.

6. Wisdom:- One should always try to gain wisdom through study, self experience and wise company.

7. Control of Senses:- One should keep one's sense (of action and knowledge) under control and become their master. There are five senses of Knowledge and five sense of action.

8. Knowledge:- One should acquire knowledge both of physical and spiritual domain from all possible sources

9. Truth:- One should practice truth in thought, words and deed

10. Non Anger: - One should try to remain calm and balanced even in the face of

provocation. **ARTHA (Wealth)**

ARTHA or the acquisition of wealth is the second most important pursuit or objective of human life. DHARMA comes first and ARTHA has to be based on Dharma. The observance of DHARMA takes priority. The following are the forms of ARTHA:-

1. Knowledge is the greatest wealth; both material and spiritual. Material Knowledge relates to our worldly life, requirements and activities, while spiritual knowledge relates to spirit, God and inner life. Material knowledge is necessary to live worldly life and it can be gained thru proper education, intellectual pursuits and everyday experience, etc. However, the spiritual knowledge is much difficult to acquire. Spiritual knowledge leads to self realisation. It can be attained through the hard practice of yogic discipline

2. Health is another form of Wealth. One has to acquire and practice the knowledge of attaining good health, which includes the well being at physical, emotional and mental levels. Good food, proper regular exercise and good thoughts are some of the fundamentals of good health.

3. Contentment is another wealth. It means abstinence of desire to possess more and more of life requirements and material possessions. It also implies that one should work honestly, try his best and be satisfied with the results of his efforts. Contentment give mental peace and moral strength to remain calm in all circumstances

4. Material Wealth is another wealth. It should be acquired keeping the DHARMA. Some portion of money should be used for charitable purposes. It should be expended only for the necessities and not for one's greed (luxuries). One should not become slave of the material wealth but should master it.

KAMA (Controlled fulfillment of desires)

The third pursuit of Life is KAMA - the desire for the satisfaction of sensual urges in which sexual gratification occupies the prime position. On a wider scale, it includes fulfillment of other material desires also.

KAMA is two faceted.

- One (controlled and beneficial desire) acts as a catalytic agent for actions in life. Much of the personal and worldly progress is the result of desire to achieve something, to discover something new.

- Another (uncontrolled or not beneficial desire) can lead to destruction.

It is therefore utmost important to gain knowledge on differentiating between the facets and then to entertain the desires in a controlled way. Let us now examine how desires are produced.

- Desires are produced in the mind through thought process when mind dwells on the objects of senses. When this happens, attachment to external objects is produced. From attachment springs desire.

- The desire goes on increasing and one desire leads to another and so on. Like fire to which fuel is added, KAMA grows more and more with indulgence and is overwhelmed by KAMA, the soul also gets deluded and the result is deterioration and destruction.

- Therefore, we should keep KAMA under proper check and at its desirable level in order to make life useful and purposeful.

- We should limit our desires to as low as necessary for the daily living and fulfilling one's duties. Desires which arise out of lust, greed and anger should be curbed absolutely.

- Such control should be enforced from the beginning through wisdom and discrimination. In another words, control of desires should be observed through proper understanding about the consequences of the desires; and should not be by suppression as suppressed desires will bounce back. Repeated reminders, checks and strong determination are useful tools to avoid harmful desires. The observance of principles of DHARMA plays a vital role in the curbing and control of unwanted and harmful desires.

MOKSHA (SALVATION)

This the fourth a final objective of human life. It is the state of liberation from misery and pain which are so abundant in human life. It is the state of Ananda (perfect bliss) after attaining which nothing more remains to be attained.

Human life is unique. He (/she) is at the top of all creation. Only human beings, unlike other living beings, are endowed with higher intelligence, an ability to think, analyse and discriminate between right and wrong. Unless these endowments are used to full advantage, there is not much difference between human and animal life. Only human beings can go beyond the animal level and reach higher spiritual goals.

The attainment of MOKSHA is extremely difficult to achieve. This usually takes efforts on many births (and rebirths) and may or may not be achieved in one's current span of life except in a few rare cases. It requires arduous spiritual practice, constant and unselfish devotion to GOD an attitude of non-attachment, etc. Our knowledge, selfless action, pure and constant devotion are some of the means which are helpful in attaining MOKSHA.

The attainment of Moksha is the highest goal of life. This the final objective of human life. But there is no instant Moksha. One has to first go through and attain the first three objectives of DHARMA, ARTHA and KAMA. Taking sanyasa (renunciation) from the very beginning from world life, except in certain rare cases, is not recommended. Life has to be first lived at the material level, when ARTHA (wealth) has to be acquired and subsequently all noble desires have to be fulfilled, but all these are required to be attained within the constraints of DHARMA. Thus KAMA and ARTHA have to be accommodated within the over all control of DHARMA

UPANISHADS

Introduction

Upanishad is considered to be the end portions of the Veda (Vedanta). They represent the philosophical wisdom of the classical Indian tradition. Some hold that there are more than two hundred of them and for some only hundred eight. However some of the Upanishads are considered to be very important for any philosophical discussion as the great acharyas wrote commentaries on them. They are: Isha, Kena, Katha, Prashna, Mundaka, Mandukya, Taittirīya, Chandogya, Brihad arnyaka. These Upanishad represent all the four Vedas as they do not belong to any single Veda. Many are omitted for the contents of those lesser known Upanishads are already found in the above mentioned major Upanishad. Let us discuss in detail the philosophical significance of each of them.

ईश-के न-कठ-प्रश्न-मुण्ड-माण्डू क्य-तततिरि।

ऐतियं च छान्दोग्यं बृहदिण्यकं तथा ॥



What is Upanishad?

The term Upanishad means to sit nearby or close by. The deserving disciples used to sit close to the teacher (guru) in order to have knowledge of them. It is difficult to state anything about the great Upanishadic teachers and inquirers of truth. Sometimes their names are mixed up with the gods or mythological or historical persons. The philosophy of Upanishad is not a system of philosophy but several philosophical doctrines are brought together in these texts. Upanishad do not belong to the same time or place. They are also not composed by the same authors. Hence one finds different views and interpretations on the same texts. There is no uniform method followed in explaining the contents of the Upanishad and sometimes the methods do not adhere to any logic. Myths, etymologies, analogies, dialogues are used to explain philosophical purport of the Upanishad. They are the only logical proof.

The Upanishadic Personages

There is a tendency to mix up mythological persons, deities and historical persons in the Upanishad. We come across these names in the form of dialogues and narratives. For instance we often come across the names such as Yajnyavalkya, the spiritual guru of Janaka, It is believed that both lived around 9th century B.C. It appears that the former appeared in many controversies with many philosophers. The names of Maitreyi and Gargi, the two wives of Yajnyavalkya, also found in the Upanishdic literature. The other prominent names that one comes across in this literature include Śanatkumāra, Nārada, Sāndilya, Ajātaśatru, Gārgya, Bhrugu, Aupamānyava, Aśvapati, Buḍila, Gautama, Kausitaki, Raikva, Naciketa. The discussions, dialogues, and analogies are interrelated, overlapping and repetitious. It is very difficult to say very definitely who is earlier and who is later. Those names appeared in the earlier Upanishads are likely to be earlier than those appeared in the later Upanishad.

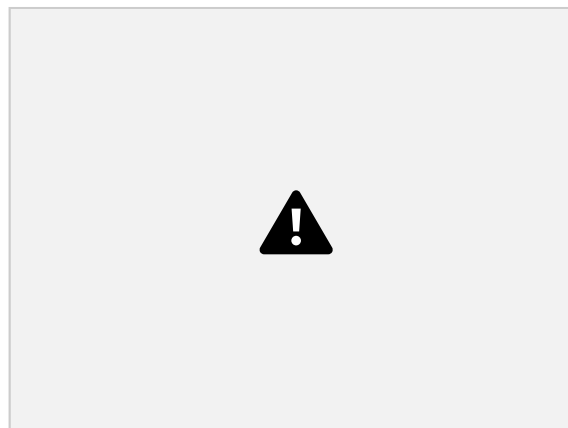
The Vedas find their final expression in the Upanishads. Indeed, the Upanishads are called "Vedanta". They form the final part of the Vedas in two ways. In each recension we have first the Samhita, then the Brahmana which is followed by the Aranyaka, the Upanishad coming at the close of the last-mentioned. The Upanishads throw light on the meaning and the purpose of the Vedas and represent the end of the scripture in more than one sense: while their text forms the concluding part of the Vedas, their meaning represents the Ultimate Truth of the same. A village or town has a temple; the temple has its gopuram; and the gopuram has a sikhara over it. The Upanishads are the sikhara, the summit, of our philosophical [and metaphysical] system.

"Upa-ni-sad" means to "sit near by". The Upanishads are the teachings imparted by a guru to his student sitting by his side [sitting at his feet]. You could also take the term to mean "that which takes one to the Brahman". "Upanayana" may be interpreted in two ways: leading a child to his guru; or leading him to the Brahman. Similarly, the term Upanishad could also be understood in the above two senses.

If a student sits close to the teacher when he is receiving instruction it means that a "rahasya" (a secret or a mystery) is being conveyed to him. Such teachings are not meant to be imparted to those who are not sufficiently mature and who are not capable of cherishing their value. That is why in the Upanishads themselves these words occur where subtle and esoteric truths are expounded: "This is Upanishat. This is Upanishad". What is held to be a secret in the Vedas is called a "rahasya". In the Upanishads the term "Upanishat" is itself used to mean the same.

Central Teachings of the Upanishad:

By and large, the central doctrines of the Upanishad focus mainly on the ultimate Reality Brahman/Atman. Several illustrations are found in different Upanishad about the nature of Brahman/Atman and how it can be realized. Let us see how the following Upanishad discuss the ultimate truth.



Isha Upanishad:

This Upanishad is the part of Sukla-Yajurveda. It starts with a prayer which states that this and the other world are full. Even if something is taken out or something is added to the full, the full remains as it is. This is the doctrine of the infinite to which the addition or subtraction make no difference. Regarding Brahman this Upanishad says that it is One and does not move, yet it is faster than mind. It is far yet it is nearer. It is outwards, yet inwards to us. Those who take to the life of action (karma) are ignorant and go to the darker worlds. Through action we can only purify our minds. It is only through meditation we attain immortality. Everything in this world is pervaded by the Lord.

ईशावास्यतमदंसंव्यक्तिकञ्चजगत् जगत्।

तेनत्क्तेनभुञ्जीथामागृधः कस्यत्किद्धनम्।।

All this should be covered by the Lord, whatsoever moves on the earth. By such a renunciation protect (thyself). Covet not the wealth of others.

Kena Upanishad:

This Upanishad belongs to Samaveda. It raises the question: What is it that impels the senses and mind to perceive and understand? What is it that sustains all, but which nothing sustains? He who says that he knows it does not really know it, and he who says that does not know it indeed knows it. That is the Atman, the Brahman. Without it the sense, mind, and even the gods can do nothing. In this Upanishd we come across the idea that Vidya (Logos or the Higher Reason) is the same as Uma, the wife of Lord Shiva by knowing which alone one can know the Brahman. Of the gods, Indra (the deity of our intelligence, buddhi, according to some commentators) also was able to see Vidya and recognise her as such.

Yakshopakhyan

God verily obtained victory for the Devas or good forces (against evil forces). The Devas felt proud in this victory of God. They thought ‘this victory is our own, this is our own greatness’. God verily knew about their pride and appeared to them. They did not know who this adorable one (Yaksha) was.

‘The word Deva in Vedic literature does not necessarily mean ‘God’, it is used in a very wide sense and literally means ‘shining’ from the root div –‘to shine’. They said to Agni ‘O, all knower! Find him out, who this adorable one is,’ Agni answered ‘Let it be so. He approached (Yaksha) who said to him, ‘Who are thou?’ Agni replied, ‘I am Agni or I am Jataveda (All knower)’. (Yaksha said) ‘What power is in thee so styled?’ (Agni answered) ‘I can burn all that is on this earth’. The Yaksha put a straw before him (Agni) and said: ‘Burn this’, Agni approached it with all its might, but was not able to burn it. He at once desisted from it, and (said to the Devas) ‘I was unable to find out who this adorable one is.’ Then they said to Vāyu. ‘O, Vayu find this out, who this adorable one is.’ He (Vayu) approached (Yaksha who said): ‘Who are you?’ VAYU answered, ‘I am Vāyu indeed. I am Matarishva (mover in space). (The Yaksha said): ‘What power is there in thee so styled?’ (Vayu answered) ‘I can blow or carry away all that exists on this earth’. (The Yaksha) put a straw to him (and said) ‘Blow this away. ‘He approached it with all his strength, but was not able to carry it away, He desisted from it, (and said to Devas): ‘I am unable to find out who this adorable one is.’ Then they said to Indra, ‘O, Mighty one! Find this out who this adorable one is.’ ‘Be it so,’ (said Indra) He approached Yaksha who disappeared from there. In that very space he came near a fair woman, Umā, well adored and decked in gold. He asked her, ‘Who is this adorable one?’

The story of the Yaksha’s appearance is to illustrate the quelling of pride. The quelling of pride is necessary before the realisation of Divinity.

The total cessation of individuality through a dissolution of the ego in knowledge is required before the achievement of Self realization.

Katha Upanishad:

This Upanishad belongs to Sāmaved. This is one of the philosophically important Upanishad. It teaches about the knowledge of what happens to man after death. Such knowledge is more valuable than any other knowledge in the world for it is none other than the knowledge of the Atman, which is the smaller than the smallest, and the greater than the greatest. The objects are the higher than the senses, and the mind higher than the objects, the individual’s reason (buddhi) higher than mind, the Cosmic reason (Mahat) higher than the individual reason, the

Unmanifest (Avyakta), the same as the goddess Aditi of the Vedas, higher than the Cosmic Reason, and the Purusha (Atman) is the higher than the Unmanifest. There is nothing higher than the Purusha. The Atman cannot be understood by reason. It has to be grasped only as 'Is'. It can be realized by withdrawing speech (senses) into mind, mind into reason (jnanyan Atman), the reason into the Cosmic Reason (Maha Atman), and that into Atman of Peace (Shanta Atman).

आत्मानं तिथनंतवत्कद्धर्षिं तिथमेवतु।

बुत्कद्धंतुसितथंतवत्कद्धमनः प्रग्रहमेवच

The body is the chariot, Soul is riding on it, the intellect is the charioteer or the driver, the mind is the rein, the senses are the horses, the objects of the senses are the roads. **Story of Nachiketa:**

There is an inspiring story in the Kath Upanishad about a little boy named Nachiketa. He was the son of Udalak rishi. Once Udalak organized a yagna to please the deities. It was customary in those days to donate cows to Brahmins at the end of the yagna. Udalak was a miser and he donated old and weak cows to the Brahmins. None of the cows yielded any milk. This disturbed Nachiketa. He asked his father about it, "Father, to whom would you give me in charity?" This made his father very angry, but he decided not to say anything. When Nachiketa repeated the question, Udalak lost his temper and said, "I give you to Yama." Yama is the king of Yamapuri

hell. Hearing this Nachiketa went to Yama's kingdom. It was his father's command. It would not be proper for him to disobey his father. 'I should fulfil his wish,' thought Nachiketa, even if it means leaving home. However his father realized his mistake and tried to stop him but Nachiketa did not stop. He reached Yama's kingdom and was told by Yama's guards that he had gone out for three days. Nachiketa decided to wait at his doorstep till he returned. He waited for three days. No food, no water. Three fasts! Yama returned on the fourth day and saw little Nachiketa at his doorstep. He felt pained for keeping a Brahmin waiting without welcoming him, without food and water. It was a sin not to welcome an atithi -guest at the doorstep. He scolded his wife Yami for not welcoming him. Both rushed around the house to serve Nachiketa. One went to fetch water. The other brought a mat for him to sit on. Yama still did not feel completely satisfied in serving him. So he told Nachiketa, "Dear child, I have offended you by keeping you waiting for three days. To wash my sin I request you to ask for three boons." Nachiketa declared, "My first wish is, when I return home may my father welcome me lovingly. My second wish is to grant me the knowledge by which I can be worthy of living in the heavens. My third and last wish is to grant me Atmajnyanm -knowledge of the

atma." Yama granted the first two boons immediately and tried to convince Nachiketa to give up his third wish. He offered him gold, pearls, coins, horses' elephants and even the happiness of Swarg -heaven instead. "No, I do not wish for anything else," replied Nachiketa firmly. Finally, Yama granted him the third boon too, and Nachiketa was enlightened with the knowledge of the atma. Nachiketa inspires us to be kind to all creatures, to respect one's parents, to be strong willed to do something one has decided, even in the face of difficulties and obstacles and to seek for eternal happiness.



Two path from Kathopanishads

The two leading paths, the good (Shreyas) and the pleasant (Preyas), have different aims, and they drag a person from different directions.

Of these two, he who chooses the good obtains blessings, but he who chooses the pleasant, deviates from his aim.

All pleasant things shall vanish, and only the good shall remain.

One cannot pursue the good and the pleasant at the same time, even as light and darkness cannot be perceived in the same place.

Prashna Upanishad:

This Upanishad belongs to Atharvaveda. In this Upanishad the sage Pippalāda answers six very important questions asked by six different enquirers. The questions and their answers are mixed up with some mythological stuff. The first question is: How were creatures created? Prajāpati, the creator God did penance and through it created couples (polar opposites), which in turn created the world of beings. The couples were Rayi (material stuff) and Prāṇa (the life principle). The life principle is the Cosmic Person (Vaishvanara). This life principle is one's Atman. The second question is: Who are gods? And who among them is the greatest? The gods are Ether (akash), Air, Fire, Water, Earth, Speech, Mind, Eye and Ear. Greater than all of them is Prshna, the life principle. All other gods for their function are dependent on it. The third question is: What is the origin of Prana? How does it divide itself into senses, etc., of man? It is the reflection of Atman and employs its divisions for performing different functions in the

body. The fourth question is: What happens to the gods in sleep and who is it that sleeps? In sleep all the senses become one with the god of mind.



Only Prana, the life principle, and its involuntary activities continue to work. They do not sleep at all. In dream the agent experiences whatever is experienced during the waking state

again and even what is not then experienced. In dreamless sleep the agent is overpowered by a psyche force (tejas) the fire of his conscious being or its intense light and does not see dreams. Like birds resting on a tree everything rests in Atman. The fifth question is: What does the word 'Aum' represents? It is same as the Brahman, both manifest and unmanifest together. The sixth question is about Purusha (Atman). There are sixteen phases of it. They are: Prana, Faith, the five elements, all the senses taken together, mind, food, semen, penance, sacred word, ethical action, the worlds, and name. All of them are fixed to the Atman like spokes in the axle. Atman is the center and circumference of the Universe.

Mundaka Upanishad:

This Upanishad belongs to Atharvaveda. It distinguishes higher knowledge from lower one. The former is the knowledge of Brahman/Atman and the latter is the knowledge of empirical sciences, Vedas and their subsidiaries. Just as spider throws out its web and withdraws it into itself again, Atman throws the world out of itself and withdraws itself into itself. The life of action and sacrifices are simply unstable, they belong to the world of ignorance. The lower spirit in man looks for worldly benefits and the higher simply remains as a witness. It is often compared with two birds, one as a witness and the other as the bhokta. The former is the higher spirit and the latter is the lower one. It is the lower spirit which is subject to the rewards and punishments depending upon its merits and demerits. But it can overcome its bondage by realizing the higher spirit. Atman cannot be known through intellect or by study. One can know it only when one is chosen by it

Mandukya Upanishad:

This Upanishad belongs to Atharvaveda. it is said that- 'māndūkyam ekam eva alam mumukshūnām vimuktaye' for the liberation of the mumukshū or seeker the Māndūkyā alone is enough; and if you are able to understand the true meaning of this single Upanishad, there may not be a necessity to study any other Upanishad.

Mandukya upnishad contains only 12 mantras. It is the smallest Upnishad having the explanation of 'Om' - Ōmityetadakṣharamidam sarvam, tasyopavyākhyānam, bhūtam bhavātbhaviṣyaditi sarvatomkāra eva; yaccānyat trikālātītam tadapyomkāra eva. The Imperishable is OM, and it is 'all this'. Everything else, whatever be of the past, present or future, is like an exposition, explanation or commentary on the meaning of this great Truth – the Imperishable Om. Sarvam Omkāra eva: Everything is Om, indeed. This is how the Upanishad begins. Ōm ityetadakṣharam idam sarvam: All this, whatever is visible, whatever is cognizable, whatever can come within the purview of sense-perception, inference or verbal testimony, whatever can be comprehended under the single term, creation – **all this is Om.**

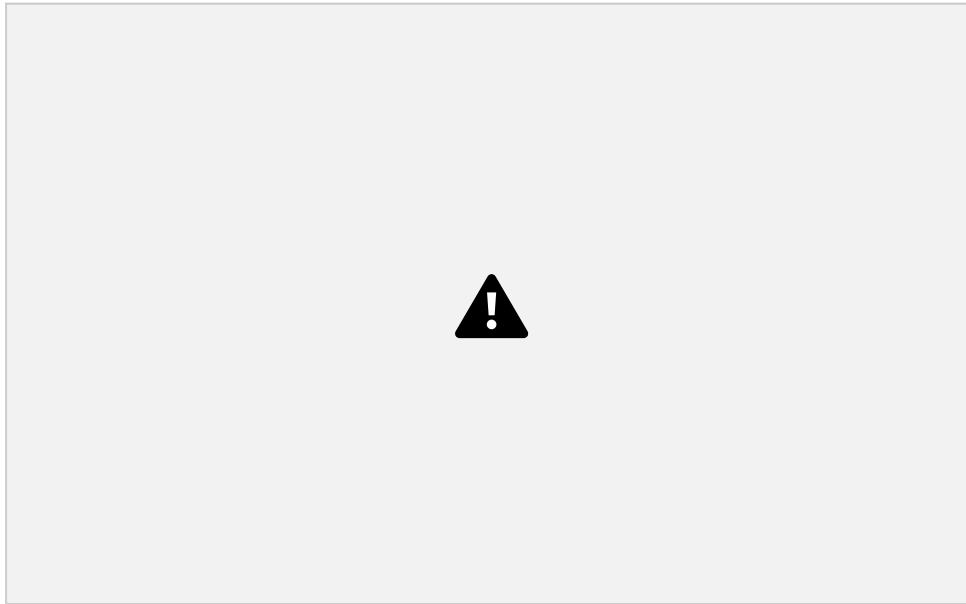
This Upanishad contains the gist of the rest. It teaches us that Atman has four states. They are: waking (jagrt), dream (svapna), deep-sleep (sushupti) and its original pure state (turiya). In the first state the consciousness of the Atman is directed towards external material objects. In this state it has seven parts and nineteen gateways. The seven parts are: forehead, eyes, the life principle (prana), bodily center, abdomen, feet, and face. The nineteen gateways are: the five senses (ear, eye, taste, touch, and smell), the five organs of action (hands, feet, the generative organ, the excretory organ), the five vital principles (pran , apan, udan , vyan , and saman), the four inner and internal instruments (manas , ahamkar , buddhi and citta). The Atman in this state is worldly or mundane person (Vaishvanara). In dream state it has all the seven parts and nineteen gates, but its consciousness is turned towards the dream objects. These objects are not made up of gross matter. In this state the Atman is called psyche (Taijasa) for its

experience is constituted by psychic force. In the state of deep-sleep the Atman sees no dreams and desires nothing. Its consciousness is its only gate and all plurality becomes one with it. This state of Atman is called Prana, for it is pure and undifferentiated.

The fourth state is the pure state of Atman. In this state it is beyond thought and speech. It knows itself without any medium. It is free from the Unconscious.

Taittirīya Upanishad:

This Upanishad belongs to Sāmaveda. It talks about five types of union. They are: the union of physical elements like earth, water, air etc., the union of shining objects such as sun, fire, lightening; the union of knowledge like that in the teacher, student, and lectures; the union of creative beings like father, mother, and creation; and the union of physiological parts like upper jaw, lower jaw, and speech. The Brahman is the Truth, the Consciousness and the Infinite. From it born is ether, from ether air, from air fire, from fire water, and from water earth. And from earth are born plants, from plants food, from food Purusha (Atman) or man as 'I'. Since he eats, swallows, absorbs the different elements he is called Atman. It is enveloped by annamayakosha, pranomayakosha, manomayakosha, vijnyanmayakosha and anandamayakosha. The first two kosha belong to gross body (sthulasharira) and the rest to belong to subtle body (sukshmatharira) and the last kosha belong to causal body (karansharira). Each latter stage is the atman of the former. According to this Upanishad everything originated from Non-being in the sense that the Reality in the beginning is indeterminate, and it was the Unmanifest (avyakta). The bliss of the Atman is greater than everything else.



We observed that our individuality is constituted of different layers, and these layers are called *koshas* in Sanskrit.

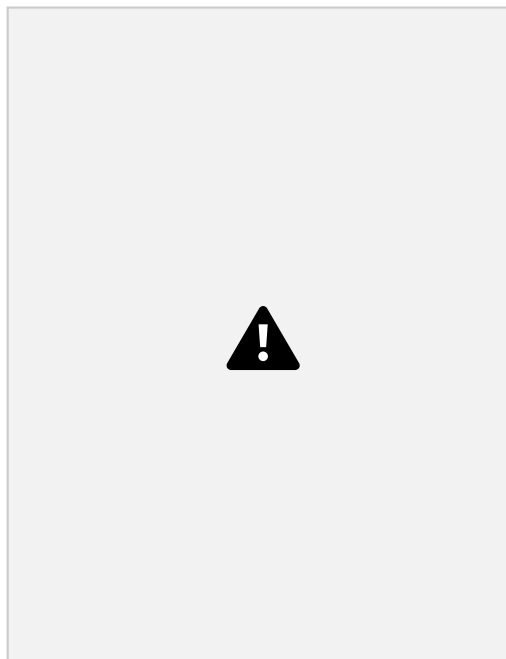
There are primarily five such *koshas*, or sheaths, in which our consciousness is enveloped: •

Annamaya Kosha- *Anna* means food; *Maya* means 'filled with'. The first '*kosha*' speaks about importance of food which forms the basic necessity for human survival

- Pranamaya Kosha- *Prana* means breath; *Maya* means 'filled with'. The second '*kosha*' discusses the impact of science of breathing on human emotions

- Manomaya Kosha- *Man* means mind; *Maya* means 'filled with'. The state of mind and journey of thoughts forms the basis of this '*kosha*'

- Vidnyanmaya Kosha- *Vidnyan* means knowledge; *Maya* means 'filled with'. The conversion of thoughts during the phase of Manomaya Kosha, into worldly knowledge of real and unreal entities forms Vidnyanmaya Kosha
- Anandmaya Kosha- Taittiriya Upanishad discusses the nature of the innermost sheath in us, called the Anandamaya Kosha. The causal innermost sheath, which is the most subtle and pervasive in our personality, is called the Anandamaya Kosha. It is called Anandamaya because it is characterized by blissfulness or happiness. '*Ananda*' means happiness; *Maya* means 'filled with'. It is filled with and constituted of happiness only, warp and woof.



Aitareya Upanishad:

This Upanishad belongs to Rigveda. It gives a semi-mythological account of creation. Atman correlates the microcosm and macrocosm and the gods become the psycho-physical principles. This Upanishad ends with a saying that all the mental functions are only names of our rational consciousness (prajnyanmay) and that our rational consciousness is the Brahman.

Chandogya Upanishad:

This Upanishad belongs to Rigveda. It is second largest of the Upanishads. After liberation man's spirit rests with the gods and the Brahman in the highest world, according to this Upanishad. This conception is theistic. However, the Upanishad says that 'everything is verily the Brahman'. It is the innermost to us. Brahman is the smallest yet the largest. Uddālaka Aruṇi teaches his son Shvetaketu that in deep sleep speech enters mind; mind the life principle (prana), the life principle the psychic force (tejas), the psychic force the supreme Deity. All these belong to Atman and "That art thou (tattvamasi). Just as different rivers merge into the same ocean and lose their self-identity, so everything ultimately enters the Atman and becomes one with it. The idea of the person in the eye is elaborated in this Upanishad. Vairocana, the king of the Demons, and Indra, the king of the gods, approached Prajāpati, the creator god, to be taught about the Atman which is without disease and death. As the story goes, Prajāpati told them that the person seen in the eye was Atman. He asked both of them to adorn themselves and look at their reflections in a pot of water, and what they

would see was the Atman. Following the advice of Prajāpati, Vairocana saw the reflection of his own body in the water pot, and began to worship himself as the Atman, indulging himself in all the pleasures of his body. Similarly, Indra also followed the advice of Prajāpati and saw his perishable body in the water-pot, and doubted how his perishable body could be the Atman which is imperishable. So he came back to Prajāpati for further instruction. Prajāpati told him that the person in the deep sleep and dreamless sleep is Atman. It is the seer and is beyond deep-sleep and bodiless. It is unfettered and suffers no pain and pleasure. Therefore, “I am all this (ahameva idam sarvam).

PART B: Doctrines of Upanishads

UPANISHADS - THE SCIENCE OF SELF

The famous physicist Neil Bohr says “we are both spectators and actors in the great drama of existence”. According to Upanishads, human existence is a mystery and it holds the key to other mysteries of the universe. The ‘science of human possibilities’ is what India found in the Upanishads and developing this science is an attempt to unfold the very existence of human beings. The sole purpose of Vedas is the welfare of all beings which can only be achieved by delving deeper into your true self and exploring those depths. Upanishads offered a great insight into ‘the science of thyself’ or self discovery. The more you delve deeper, the more you are closer to the ultimate truth of life. According to Upanishads, a human’s soul is equal to soul of the universe. If you unravel the mystery of your own self, you will unravel the mystery of the universe.

• Atman

Atman could not be described as a positive entity. It has been sought to be defined by characteristics which are contradictory to one another. For instance, it has been held that atman is stationary, yet faster than mind; it is near yet far, it exists inside everything and also outside. The Bhagavad Gita (II. 22-5), true to the spirit of the Upanishads, declares that weapons cannot cut atman, fire cannot burn it, water cannot damp it and wind cannot make it dry. It is further stated (II.20) that atman remains unaffected even when the body is killed.

The same atman has different experiences in the three states of jagrat (waking), svapna (sleep) and susupti (deep slumber). Beyond these stages is the condition called turiya, the fourth state in which the soul becomes one with Brahman (Supreme Spirit). The individual soul is covered by five koshas (vestures), viz., pranamaya (made of vital air), annamaya (made of food), manomaya (made of mind), vijñanamaya (made of intelligence) and anandamaya (made of bliss) which make the body enshrining the soul. Our ultimate goal is to realize the soul lying hidden by the above koshas like a sword covered by the scabbard.

• Brahman

Brahman and mahavakyas

The Great Utterances: The Mahavakyas are the Great Sentences of Advaita Vedanta and Jnana Yoga, and are contained in the Upanishads. Maha is Great, and Vakyas are sentences, or utterances for contemplation. They provide perspective and insights that tie the texts together in a cohesive whole. The contemplations on the Mahavakyas also blend well with the practices of yoga meditation, prayer, and mantra, which are companion practices in Yoga. The pinnacle of the wisdom and practices of the ancient sages is contained in the terse twelve verses of the Mandukya Upanishad, which outlines the philosophy and practices of the OM mantra.

These make the wisdom more accessible: Seven Mahavakyas are described below. By focusing on these seven Mahavakyas, the rest of the principles of self-exploration described in Vedanta and the Upanishads are more easily accessible. Included with the descriptions below are suggestions on what to do with these seven Mahavakyas.

Validation in the inner laboratory: To truly understand the meaning of the Mahavakyas, it is necessary to practice contemplation and meditation in your own inner laboratory of stillness and silence. It means doing a lot of self-observation, including the four functions of mind. You may find it useful to learn both the Sanskrit and the English of the Mahavakyas. They are not practiced as blind faith beliefs, but rather are reflected on, so that their meaning is validated in direct experience.

Start by hearing the insights described: Some methods of contemplation give you a principle, a word, on which to reflect, but give no clues of the insights that will come. For example, if you contemplate on the word Truth, that is very broad, and may have many meanings. It might take a long time to even come to a core principle. Sometimes, in school or elsewhere, you have probably seen a study guide that has a list of questions that also includes the answers, in a Q&A format. With the Mahavakyas, it is somewhat like that, in that the Mahavakyas provide the answers, already written down. You still have to do the contemplations, but the journey is much more direct.

Direct experience, not mere belief: In contemplating the Mahavakyas, it is not a matter of merely accepting that the statements are true. In the oral teachings of the sages, it is said that you should never merely believe what you are told or what you read in a book. Rather, it is suggested that you should check it out for yourself in the inner laboratory of direct experience. It also seems true that, while ultimate oneness is the same for all, there is also a coloring of cultural and religious influences that determine the way in which different people will experience the early, or unfolding stages of insight. Dig deep into the well of only a few such Mahavakyas.

Dig deep in only a few wells: It can appear that exploring only a few sentences, like these seven, is a mere beginning point, and that one must subsequently learn hundreds or thousands of other sentences. This is definitely not the case. Although in academic circles one may do complex intellectual analysis of many scholarly commentaries, comparing and contrasting viewpoints, the seeker of direct experience digs deep into the well of only a few such contemplations. In the monastic traditions of the swami order, a monk may contemplate exclusively on a single Mahavakya or maybe several of them. The practice bears fruit by deeply going into one, or a few, rather than memorizing many, or doing only intellectual analysis of the many.

Mahavakyas are at the heart of Vedanta: These seven principles below are practices at the heart of the Vedanta part of the triad. Actually, all of these emerged out of the one source of teachings, and now appear to be three separate practices. The higher understanding and direct experience comes from person-to-person listening (written and oral), followed by deep reflection, contemplation, and deep contemplative meditation.

Advaita or Non-Dual Reality: Advaita is exactly what it says, Advaita, which means non duality, not-two. If this little planet were to fall into the sun and burn up, there would no longer be any religionists or philosophers, but that which truly "is" still "is." Advaita is exactly what

it says it is, Advaita, not-two, which stands alone. Any suggestion that there are things such as Hindu Advaita or Buddhist Advaita or Anything-Else Advaita are games of the mind. To transcend all of the levels of false identity so as to "Be" that Reality of Advaita is the Knowledge or Jnana that is sought. It is only the most sincere and longing of aspirants who seek and know this in direct experience. For others, it is merely an arena of philosophical and religious debate. For those who Know, Advaita stands alone.

Who am I? It has become very popular in recent years to criticize the practice of Mahavakyas, suggesting instead that one simply ask "Who am I?" and then reject any response which arises from within (other than "I am that!")? It is commonly suggested that one NOT contemplate any of the phrases such as "Aham Brahmasmi" ("I am Brahman, the Absolute Reality"). Such suggestions to NOT practice Mahavakyas presuppose the incorrect opinion that contemplation on Mahavakyas is only a mere mental process, missing the fact that the Mahavakya leads one to deep silence wherein the reality is experienced directly. Contemplation on the Mahavakyas is not mere chanting of mantras or reprogramming the mind with affirmations as if one were trying to inculcate an alternative belief system. It moves in stages, culminating in the highest of direct experience of the meaning of the Mahavakyas. Contemplation on the Mahavakyas and the question "Who am I?" are not in conflict with one another. Rather, they go hand in hand, in a systematic, unified practice.

Meaning of word Brahman

Root of the word: The word Brahman comes from the root brha or brhi, which means knowledge, expansion, and all-pervasiveness. It is that existence which alone exists, and in which there is the appearance of the entire universe.

Not subject to change: Brahman means the absolute reality, that which is eternal, and not subject to death, decay, or decomposition. In English, we speak of omnipresence or oneness. This is the principle of the word Brahman.

Not a proper name: Brahman is not a proper name, but a Sanskrit word that denotes that oneness, the non-dual reality, the substratum underneath all of the many names and forms of the universe. Brahman is somewhat like the difference between the word ocean, and the specific ocean called Pacific Ocean. The word Brahman is like ocean, not Pacific Ocean. Brahman is not a name of God. These contemplations neither promote nor oppose any particular religious concept of God.

It's really indescribable, as it is beyond form: However one chooses to hold the word Brahman, it is very useful to remember that Brahman is often described as indescribable. For convenience sake, it is said that Brahman is the nature of existence, consciousness, and bliss, though admitting that these words, too, are inadequate.

Seek direct experience: The real meaning comes only in direct experience resulting from contemplation and yoga meditation.

1. Brahma satyam jagan mithya- The absolute is real; the world is unreal or only relatively real

Brahman is real: The way in which Brahman is real is like saying that the clay in a pot is real, or the gold in a bracelet is real (metaphorically speaking). The idea is that first there was clay and gold, and when those changed form, there now appears to be a pot and a bracelet.

The world is unreal: However, when the pot is broken, or the bracelet is melted, there is once again only clay and gold. It is in that sense that the pot and the bracelet are not real; they come and go from manifestation. They are not as real as are the clay and the gold. (Remember that these are metaphors, and that obviously, we could also say that clay and gold also come and go, such as when planets are born and die from the nuclear fire of suns. Also, note that using the English words real and unreal for the Sanskrit words satyam and mithya, are not perfect, but they are the best we have to work with.)

Something is more real than the temporary: In saying that the world is unreal, it means to say that literally everything we experience in the external world is, like the pot and the bracelet, in a process of coming, being, and going (so too with all of the objects of the subtle realm). If the Mahavakya stopped there, this might appear to be a negative, or depressing comment. But it does not stop there. It makes the added comment that this absolute reality is, in a sense, more real than the temporary appearances.

Two points: Thus, the Mahavakya does two major things:

- **Reminder of the temporary:** First, it serves as a reminder of the temporary nature of the worldly objects.
- **Reminder of the eternal:** Second, it serves as a reminder that there is an eternal nature that is not subject to change.

An invitation to know: In these reminders there is an invitation to come to know, in direct experience, the existence, consciousness, and bliss that is this eternal essence of our being.

Don't stop living in the world: When practicing contemplation with this, and the other Mahavakyas, it is important to not allow the reflection that the world is unreal to stop you from doing your actions in the external world. To think that the world is unreal, and therefore we need not do anything is a grave mistake. The realization of the unreality of the world and the reality of the essence behind the world brings freedom, not bondage or lethargy. .

- **Brahma satyam jagan mithya** Brahman is real; the world is unreal (The absolute is real; the world is unreal or only relatively real)

What to do: The purpose of contemplation and yoga meditation exercises is to attain Self realization, or enlightenment, which has to do with knowing or experiencing the deepest, eternal aspect of our own being. By working with this Mahavakya, one increasingly sees the difference between what is temporary and what is eternal.

- **Be mindful of the passing objects:** One way to work with this Mahavakya, is to simply be mindful of the world around you. Gradually, gently, and lovingly observe the countless objects that are ever in a process of coming and going.
- **Remember the eternal:** Allow yourself to also remember the eternal nature that is always there, enjoying the beauty of how this process ebbs and flows through that unchanging, eternal essence.

Be mindful of your own temporary and eternal: As you witness the external world in this way, allow your attention to shift to your own physical, energetic, and mental makeup. Gradually comes the insight that these more surface aspects are also temporary, and in a sense, are also unreal, or only relatively real. It increasingly allows the mind to see that there is an eternal aspect of our being, and that this is actually the source of the mind itself. The mind

comes to see that it must, itself, let go, so as to experience the eternal that is within.

Practice this at daily meditation time: By observing the world in this way, it is then easier to do the same kind of silent observation and contemplation while sitting in the stillness of your meditation time. Over time, the depth of the insights increase, as an inner expansion comes.

The different Mahavakyas work together: In practice, the Mahavakyas work together. This becomes evident by exploring the others, such as the ones that follow below.

2. Ekam evadvitiam brahma - Brahman is one, without a second - (There is one absolute reality, without any secondary parts)

No object is truly independent: As our attention goes from object to object, image to image, we keep finding that those objects and images are only relatively real (as discussed above). Gradually, we come to see that no object exists independently from Brahman, the whole. Hence, it is said there is one, without a second. Wherever we look, whatever we think or feel, try as we will, we can find no second object or part. Everything is seen as a manifestation of something else.

The objects are made of the same stuff: To speak of one, without a second, is like thinking of thousands of pots or bracelets made from clay or gold. As you look at each of the pots and bracelets, one at a time, you conclude that this pot, and this bracelet is not separate from the whole field of clay and gold. Suddenly you come to the insight that there is not a single pot that is separate from clay, and there is not a single bracelet separate from gold. In other words, you see that there is one field, without a second object, or simply stated, there is one, without a second.

Once again, this can also be viewed in a theological way, wherein immanence (versus transcendence) means the divinity existing in, and extending into all parts all parts of the created world. Thus, there is no object that does not contain, or is not part of that creation.

• Ekam evadvitiam brahma Brahman is one, without a second (There is one absolute reality, without any secondary parts)

What to do: Keep exploring the latter part of the sentence, the part of being without a second. Consciously look at the objects of the world, and the thoughts that arise in the mind. Observe whether it has independent existence and permanence. It is like asking, "Does this object or thought exist on its own? Does it stay in this form, or does it go away? Is it, therefore a second object in comparison to the whole?"

- **Try to find a second object:** One practice is to repeatedly look for some second object, which has independent existence from the whole, from Brahman.
- **You'll find there is none:** The aspirant will repeatedly find that there is no second object, which has independent existence, but that all objects derive from some other, like the pots from clay, or bracelets from gold. This brings the increasing awareness of underlying wholeness.

See the beauty of oneness in diversity: If this is approached as a mere philosophical opinion, if we merely believe the principle, then the deep insight that comes from exploration will be missed. Each time that some new object or thought is seen to not be a second in relation to the whole, the personal realization of the truth of the principle will become deeper and more

profound. We come to see the beauty in this, to see the joy of wholeness, of the unity within the diversity. The interrelationship between the Mahavakyas will also become clearer.

3. Prajnanam brahman - Brahman is the supreme knowledge (Knowing the absolute reality is the supreme knowledge) (from Aitareya Upanishad of Rig Veda)

Knowledge out of which other knowledge arises: There are many types of knowledge one can attain. However, they all stem from, or are a part of, a higher knowledge. There is one exception, and that is the absolute knowledge, which is the highest. It is called absolute because it is not stemming from something else. Supreme knowledge is the ground out of which the diversity of knowledge and experience grows. The plant, though appearing separate, is made of the stuff of the ground.

Many metaphors for higher knowledge: It is just about impossible to write words describing this notion of supreme knowledge, which is part of the reason that there are so many different descriptions given by many people. Thus, we use metaphor after metaphor trying to capture and communicate the essence of the meaning. This Mahavakya is saying that as you climb the ladder of knowledge, this higher knowledge is to be found at the level of Brahman, the oneness of universal consciousness.

Reflect on lower knowledge to find the higher: Reflecting on lower knowledge might give some idea. The knowledge of how to ride a bicycle is a form of knowledge, but it is based on the higher knowledge of how to move your body. The knowledge of complex mathematics is based on the higher, more foundational, prerequisite knowledge that allows the thinking process itself. When you see a person that you recognize as your friend, there was first an ability to see and conceptualize, which is a higher knowledge.

Find the foundation: Intuitively, you come to see that there is consciousness, or whatever term you would like to use, that is higher, more foundational, or prerequisite to the lower knowledge in all of its other forms. The highest rung of the ladder is called supreme knowledge, prajna, and this is said to be one and the same with Brahman, the oneness.

Knowing is not mere intellectualizing: It is extremely important to note here, that this is not a process of intellectualizing. Knowledge refers to knowing or awareness, not just a linear, cognitive thinking process. The knowledge here, is more like the knowledge of recognizing an object as a tree, than the process of adding up a list of numbers. There is simply no more straightforward way of saying it, than to say it is a matter of knowing the tree.

Knowing applies to both head and heart people: Also, it is not that some people are intellectual, or head people, while others are emotional, or heart people. While these differences between people might be real, this Mahavakya is talking about a universal principle that applies to all people. The practices themselves are applicable to all people, whether inclined towards the head or the heart, though different people will quite naturally have different experiences leading to the same ultimate realization.

• Prajnanam brahman -Brahman is the supreme knowledge (Knowing the absolute reality is the supreme knowledge)

What to do: In trying to reflect on the nature of supreme knowledge, the eternal substratum of all other knowledge, the mind will present many memories, images, impressions, thoughts, sensations, and emotions. All of these are some form of

knowledge, that's for sure. However, they are not the highest knowledge.

Ask yourself if a knowledge is lower or higher: Simply allow these thought patterns to arise. Then ask yourself, "Is this the higher knowledge?" Repeatedly you will find that the answer is no that it is not the higher, but is a lower form of knowledge. Remember there is higher knowledge: This kind of reflection leaves a quietness in which the intuition of the existence of the higher knowledge starts to come. The intuition deepens with practice. This quietness is not one of lethargy or laziness, but rather of clarity and openness. It brings a smile to the face and to the heart, as the field of knowing gradually expands towards the wisdom of the Mahavakya.

4. Tat tvam asi –That is what you are (That absolute reality is the essence of what you really are) (from Chandogya Upanishad of Sama Veda)

That is what YOU are: This Mahavakya is stated as if one person is speaking to the other, saying, "That is what you are!" when referring to Brahman. The person speaking is the teacher, and person being spoken to is the student.

It is YOU at the deepest level: Imagine that the teacher has explained to you all of the above Mahavakyas, that you had reflected on these, and that you started to have some sense of the meaning of the oneness called brahman. Imagine that the teacher then pointed a finger at you and explained, "That brahman, that oneness, is who you really are, at the deepest level of your being!" It is like telling a wave in the ocean that it IS the ocean.



You are the person underneath the personality: Often, we hold on to our personal identities, such as being from this or that family, organization, or country. We take on the identity of our roles in our jobs or in our families, such as father or mother, sister or brother, son or daughter. Or, we come to believe that who we are, is our personality traits that have developed through living. We forget our true nature that is underneath all of these only relative identities.

We continue our duties, holding identities loosely: The realization of this Mahavakya, Tat tvam asi, leads us to see that the relative identities are not who we really are. It does not mean that we drop our duties in the world, or stop acting in service of other people because of this realization. Rather, we become ever freer to hold those identities loosely, while increasingly being able to act in the loving service of others, independent of attachment to our false identities.

- **Tat tvam asi -That is what you are (That absolute reality is the essence of what you really are)**

What to do: As if talking to yourself, direct your attention inward, possibly towards the heart center. Say to yourself, "That is who you are!" Point a finger at yourself: You might want to even point your index finger at your own chest, the place from where you experience, "I am." As you hold in awareness the essence of the truth that this Brahman, this oneness, is who you really are, also observe how you can gently let go of the false identities, seeing that they are only temporary and relatively me.

Say to yourself, "That is who you are": When reflecting on the other Mahavakyas, such as brahman is the supreme knowledge, then shift the observation from that truth, directing attention to your own inner being and say, "Tat tvam asi; That you are!" **Remember the inner feeling:** Notice the inner feeling that comes from the statement and the realization of your spiritual nature, rather than your more surface level of mental or physical identity.

5. Ayam atma brahma Atman and Brahman are the same (The individual Self is one and the same with the absolute) (from Mandukya Upanishad of Atharva Veda)

The wave and the ocean are one: Is the wave separate from the ocean? Not really, but sometimes we lose sight of that. Imagine that you are standing by the ocean, watching the vastness of the ocean. Imagine that a really big wave starts to come ashore, and that your attention comes to this one wave. You intently notice it, becoming absorbed in the crashing of the surf, and the feel of the salt spray. In that moment, you are only aware of the immensity of this one wave. The ocean itself is forgotten during that time. Then, an instant later, you recall with an inner "Aha!", that the wave and the ocean are one and the same.

- **Atman** refers to that pure, perfect, eternal spark of consciousness that is the deepest, central core of our being.
- **Brahman** refers to the oneness of the manifest and unmanifest universe.

It is like saying that atman is a wave, and Brahman is the ocean. The insight of Ayam atma brahma is that the wave and the ocean are one and the same.

Atman seems to be here, and Brahman there: Notice how the statement Ayam atma brahma (Atman and Brahman are the same) is framed as if you are a separate observer of both Atman and Brahman. It is like standing at the beach, looking out at both the wave and the ocean, and declaring that the wave and the ocean are one. You are observing from a witnessing stance, outside of both of them. Notice how this perspective contrasts with Aham brahmasmi (I am Brahman), which declares that "I am!" an inner experience, rather than from an observing standpoint (like being on the beach).

Different perspectives for the underlying reality: In this way, each of the Mahavakyas gives a different perspective of the same underlying Reality. Gradually, they are seen as mirror reflections of the same Absolute Reality. That integrated flash of insight touches on the true meaning of the word Brahman. It is like gaining different points of view from different viewing points. Together, they converge in a complete understanding.

- **Ayam atma brahma -Atman and Brahman are the same (The individual Self is one and the same with the absolute)**

What to do: Sit quietly and reflect on the inner core of your being, such as by placing your attention in the space between the breasts, the heart center.

Be aware of your center: Don't visualize anything, but allow your awareness to touch the feeling aspect of the center of your being. Or, if you like to visualize internally, imagine a tiny spark of light that represents the eternal essence your own self, the atman. Hold this attention for a few seconds or minutes.

Shift to awareness of the universe: Then, shift your attention in such a way that you are imagining the breadth of the entire manifest and unmanifest universe, the gross, subtle, and causal realms. Imagine the oneness that permeates all, and is all. Do this in a way that you are aware of the essence in which all exists, like being aware of the gold or the clay described above.

Then be aware of both as separate: Then, allow your attention to hold both the awareness of the spark that is atman and the universal essence that is Brahman. Be aware of atman also being within that oneness of Brahman. Allow this to bring insight and peace. You might want to internally think the words of the Mahavakya, "Ayam atma brahma; atman and brahman are the same."

Be aware of both as one: It is a beautiful practice to do the same thing in relation to other people. Think of the people who are closest to you, including family, friends, and coworkers. Allow yourself to notice the surface levels of their actions and speech, their physical features, and their personalities. Be aware of the subtle aspects of their makeup, and of the spark of the eternal that is the center of their consciousness. Be aware of how that spark, atman, is one with the oneness, Brahman.

Different insights from different Mahavakyas: Notice the different insights and feelings between the Mahavakyas. The insight from Tat tvam asi (That is who you are) is experienced differently from Ayam atma brahma (This individual Self is one with the absolute). The two simply feel different internally, yet they work together, describing the same fundamental truth about about who we are. By experiencing the separate vantage points, the whole is more completely experienced.

6. Aham brahmasmi - I am Brahman (Who I really am, is that absolute reality.) (from Brihadaranyaka Upanishad of Yajur Veda)

If a gold bracelet could speak: Imagine two possibilities of what a gold bracelet might say, if it could speak. It might say one of these two things:

1. "I am a bracelet!"
2. "I am gold!"

Bracelet is temporary: Which is truer, more everlasting? We might be tempted to say that #1 is more accurate, in that bracelet seems more encompassing, being both bracelet and gold at the same time. However, the bracelet aspect is not eternal. It is temporary. It is only a matter of the particular shape in which the gold was molded. Is bracelet what it really is?

Gold is everlasting: What is always true, is #2, that "I am gold," everlasting, ever pure, and not subject to death, decay, and decomposition. (One might argue that gold is not everlasting either, but in the metaphor, gold is being only used as an example.)

Bracelet is gold; I am gold: Note that this metaphor may sound similar to the ones above, regarding the impermanence of a bracelet and the permanence of the gold (metaphorically speaking). This is not the case. The realization that, "I am gold!" or "I am brahman!" is an internal experience compared to the statement, "The bracelet is gold!" (Which sounds like the bracelet over there). The two insights are separate, though they also come to be the same.

Similarly, it is very different to realize, in direct experience, "I am brahman!" than one of the statements such as, "Brahman alone is real!"

- **Out there:** "Brahman alone is real!" seems to be about the world out there. It is a valid perspective.
- **In here:** "I am brahman!" is an inner declaration of who I am, in here. This is also a valid perspective.

Truth comes in the stillness of intuitive flash: The truth of a Mahavakyacomes through intuitive flash that is progressively deeper as one practices. It is not merely an intellectual process, as it might appear to be by explaining the gold metaphor. The metaphors are used as a means of explaining the principle, but this is not the end of the process. In a sense, such explanations are only the beginning of the process. The key is in the still, silent reflection in the inner workshop of contemplation and yoga meditation.

After thinking, let go into contemplative insight: The initial insights come somewhat like the creative process when you are trying to solve some problem in daily life. You think and think, and then finally let go into silence. Then, suddenly, the creative idea just pops out, giving you the solution to your problem. The contemplation on the Mahavakyas is somewhat like that at first. Later, it goes into deeper meditation.

Insight comes within your own context: One may experience himself or herself as being like the gold or the clay, or like a wave in an ocean of bliss, that realizes the wave is also the ocean. With all these metaphors used only as tools of explanation, the insight of each person will come in the context of their own culture and religion, and will not seem foreign or unnatural. One's religious values are not violated, but rather, are affirmed.

- **Aham brahmasmi -I am Brahman (Who I really am, is that absolute reality.)**
(From Brihadaranyaka Upanishad of Yajur Veda)

What to do: Reflect on the oneness, or Brahman, and the meaning, as suggested in the practices above. Allow your attention to focus on the insights from those Mahavakyas, such as Brahman is one, without a second.

Literally ask questions of yourself: Ask yourself, internally, "Who am I? Am I this body, or do I have a body? Am I this breath, or is this breath just flowing? Am I this mind, or is this mind a manifestation of some deeper truth? Who am I, really? Who am I?"

Make your own declarations: Inside the chamber of your own being, declare to yourself, "I am brahman. I am not only a wave, I am made of ocean. I am ocean!" Allow the truth of the statements to expand. Be sure to practice such affirmations only if you have reflected on them, and find truth in them. This is not about selling yourself, but on affirming what you know.

In daily life, when sitting, or resting: As you do these contemplations, you might be right in the middle of your daily life. Or, you might be sitting straight in a formal yoga meditation posture. Or, you might be resting comfortably in a chair, on a sofa, or lying down in a relaxed position. There is a great diversity of settings in which you can do this type of contemplation.

7. Sarvam khalvidam brahma- All of this is Brahman (All of this, including me, is that absolute reality)

The various insights are revealed: Gradually, one comes to understand and increasingly experience the deeper aspects of the other Mahavakyas (the six described above):

- Brahman is real; the world is unreal.
- Brahman is one, without a second.
- Brahman is the supreme knowledge.
- That is what you are.
- Atman and Brahman are the same.
- I am Brahman.

- **Sarvam khalvidam brahma- All of this is Brahman (All of this, including me, is that absolute reality)**

What to do: Allow your awareness to try to encompass, at one time, the entire manifest and unmanifest universe, the objects and people in the world around you, as well as your own body and mind. Hold these together, as one whole, and reflect on the words, "All of this is brahman! All of this is one!" This builds on the other practices, and expands in its experience.

Mind is set aside in an explosion of awareness: Eventually, in the depth of meditation and contemplation, the entire mind is set aside in an explosion of awareness, in which the truth of the Mahavakyas comes forward, and is seen to have been there all along, ever still, waiting to be discovered in direct experience

They sing a song together: As one comes to experience the truth of the individual Mahavakyas, it seems they come together in a song that cries out in joy, "All of this is brahman!" As was said in the beginning, it is a process that comes from person-to-person listening (written and oral), followed by deep reflection, contemplation, and meditation.



Realization comes in stages:

- First, there is cognitive understanding of the meaning.
- Second, intuition rolls down, revealing deeper meanings.

- Finally, it is as if the one doing the practice travels upwards to merge in the direct experience, even though there was never any division in the first place.

Four traditional Mahavakyas

Four of the Mahavakyas above are most traditional to Vedanta. Some 1200 years ago Adi Shankaracharya assigned one Mahavakya to one of four monastic teaching centers or mutts in India.

Mahavakya Source Mutt/Center

	Atman and brahman	Puri/Govardhana
Prajnanambrahman Brahman is supreme knowledge	Aitareya Upanishad 3.3, of RigVeda	East
		Dwaraka/Sarada/Gujrat West
Tattvamasi That is what you are	Chandogya Upanishad	
		Jyoti/Badrinath North
Ayamattmabrahm are the same	Mandukya Upanishad Atharva Veda	
		1 Veda,
Aham brahmasmi I am brahman	• Maya Brihadaranyaka Upanishad	Sringeri/Mysore South

Maya means illusion, and accordingly to Vedic philosophies the world is an illusion. The world is real but is not what appears to us. It looks temporary but it has always been there and will always be there. It appears to be materialistic but actually it is spiritual. It appears to be unconscious, but in reality it is conscious. It appears that you are born and you will die, but you have always lived.

• Karma

It is most fundamental and moral law in Hinduism. Your karma defines your past and future incarnations.

• Samsara

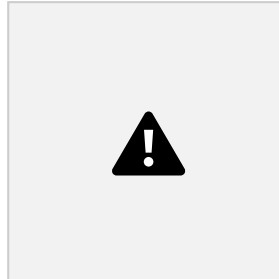
The cycle of birth, death and rebirth is called Samsara. Your reincarnation mean you are coming back to the material world again and again. We ultimately long to get rid of the cycle.

• Moksha

The stop to the cycle of reincarnation is called Mosksha. Upanishads say is the

ultimate goal of human life. It's the only goal worth pursuing. But maya or illusion does not let us see the worth of Moksha, and thus, does not let us come out of the reincarnation cycle. Moksha is the ultimate liberation soul. Of Moksha, and thus, does not let us come out of the reincarnation cycle. Moksha is the ultimate liberation soul.

RELIGIONS



Buddhism

Buddhist literature is divided into canonical and non-canonical texts. This is the most widely accepted and popular categorization of Buddhist texts.

Canonical texts

Canonical literature deals with Buddha teachings or the word of the Buddha and its main divisions are called Pitakas – Sutras, Vinaya and Abhidharma. In Pali language, together they are called Tripitakas, or “The Three Baskets”. Canonical texts are called Sutras in Sanskrit and Suttas in Pali.

Non canonical texts

Non-canonical texts are observations and commentaries on canonical texts in Pali, Tibetan, Chinese and other East Asian languages, to explain the canonical texts to monks in Sri Lanka. Pali, a Middle Indo-Aryan language of north Indian origin, is the classical and liturgical language of the Theravada Buddhism. Theravada translates to ‘the doctrines of the elders’ and these elders are referred to as senior Buddhist monks. A major chunk of the non-canonical texts were composed by the Sri Lankan monks. Non-canonical Buddhist texts also include some of the most important non-canonical works of Sri Lankan monks including The Dipavamsa (the Island Chronicle), The Mahavamsa (The Great Chronicle), and Culavamsa (the Lesser Chronicle). Non-canonical texts feature important historical information, quotes, definitions, biographical stories, rituals and jatakas (birth stories).

Theravada and Mahayana Buddhism

In the modern times, Buddhism is divided into two main branches – Theravada in Sri Lanka and Southeast Asia and Mahayana in Himalayas and East Asia. Theravada uses Buddha teachings preserved in Pali canon or Tripitaka as a core scripture. Mahayana is the largest major tradition of Buddhism with total 53% practitioners. It spreads from India to Bangladesh, Nepal, Bhutan, China and countries in Southeast Asia. It teaches that enlightenment can be attained in one's life time, even by a lay man. Mahayana considers Tripitaka as sacred text, while including other holy texts as well.

Tripitaka

Tripitaka, known as Pali canon, is the earliest collection of Buddhist writings and the word literally translates to three baskets (tri-three and pitaka = basket). Tripitaka is considered as

the core scripture in all branches of Buddhism.

1. Vinaya Pitaka

The first basket Vinaya Pitaka or Discipline basket teaches about the rules and guidelines of monastic life. From basic moral principles to guidelines on interaction between monks, nuns and ordinary people to robe-making, Vinaya Pitaka gives a deep insight into 227 regulations made for monastic discipline. The origin of these rules and further development are also explained in Vinaya Pitaka.

2. Sutta Pitaka

Sutta Pitaka, the Discourse Basket, is the largest basket consisting of the discourses ascribed to Buddha and his close disciples. Sutta Pitaka is also given the name of Buddhavacana, which simply translates to 'the word of the Buddha'. It contains the records of Buddha teachings, presents theology (study of the nature of god and religious beliefs) and a detailed account on the matters of moral behaviour for all monks. Dhammapada is the most widely known Buddhist text and an important part of Sutta Pitaka.

3. Abhidharma Pitaka

Abhidharma Pitaka or the Basket of Special Doctrines mainly consists of poetries, songs and stories that revolve around the life of Buddha and his previous lives. It comprises 7 works which mainly deal with the philosophy and doctrine of Buddhism appearing in the suttas. Many Buddhist schools do not consider Abhidharma as canonical text.

Dhammapada – The Buddha's path to wisdom

Found in Pali canon and forming the core testament of ancient Buddhism, Dhammapada or Dhammapada is a succinct expression of Buddha's teachings. It offers instructions about the true nature of your existence and help you walk the path of liberation. The teachings in Dhammapada are solely based on Buddha's understanding of reality and his clarity of thought. The one who practices these teachings attain the same level of understanding and knowledge which help extricate the root cause of suffering.

The twenty six chapters with four hundred and twenty three verses in Dhammapada throw light on the multiple aspects of Buddha teachings. Through these teachings Buddha wanted people to free themselves from the evils of hatred, passion and ignorance, in order to achieve the greatest of conquests: the conquest of self. Max Muller translated the verses of Dhammapada in 1870 and then it was later translated into many languages in many countries in the world.

Some important verses of Dhammapada

Mindfulness is a mental state achieved by focusing one's awareness on the present moment. Psychological Science Study defines it as "the non-judgemental awareness of experiences in the present moment". It is one of the most important verses that helps achieve tranquility and insight meditation.

Buddha's last verses before he died also emphasised on mindfulness, which should be endeavoured diligently to free yourself from the round of rebirths. It is believed that this verse on mindfulness had such a profound impact on Emperor Asoka of India and King Anawrahta of Burma, that they adopted Buddhism and propagated its teachings in their respective countries. One needs to practice mindfulness meditation to attain this blissful state of tranquillity.

Buddhist Quotes:

1. "All that we are, is the result of what we have thought. It is founded on our thoughts. It is made up of our thoughts. If one speaks or acts with an evil thought, pain follows one, as the wheel follows the foot of the ox that draws the wagon".

Explanation:

Every experience begins with a thought. No matter where you go, your evil acts and thoughts will follow. And it will eventually result in unpleasant circumstances and bad experiences. This is similar to the cartwheel that follows the foot of the ox that draws the wagon. However, if you act with good thoughts and good deeds, happiness will follow like a shadow that never leaves.

2. Who bears within them enmity:

"He has abused and beaten me,
defeated me and plundered me",
hate is not allayed for them.

Explanation:

Dwelling on the thought that you were insulted, robbed, assaulted and defeated will continue to increase your anger. It becomes difficult for a person to subside his anger when he keeps thinking over his imaginary trouble. This also leads to the desire to avenge. The only way to overcome your anger is forgive and forget the wrongs done to you.

3. "Better than a thousand hollow words is one useful word, hearing which one attains peace"

Explanation:

This is similar to saying the man who conquers himself is always better than a man who conquered thousands of battles. Or you can put this as conquest of self is always better than conquest of others. A single stanza that makes you feel peaceful is better than a thousand verse poem of empty sounds. With this you can relate to the common adage 'simple living and high thinking'. It highlights the beauty of minimalism in life. For example, it is always better to have single faithful friend than a bunch of fake friends.

Buddhist Philosophical Solutions

How to bring the science of happiness to life

The material and physical world keep people shackled to it and do not let them see the reality. This is the reason Buddha believed in a minimalist life, which helps illuminate the higher consciousness.

Buddha focuses people on Vimutti: Spiritual freedom which is the liberation of mind from bonds and fetters, physical and mental sufferings, wandering in samsara, and the cycle of rebirths.

Meditation is certainly one of the important techniques to control your mind.

It brings about

- I. A sense of detachment from the world
- II. Trains the mind to learn the art of living in the present, without worrying about the past or the future.

III. Helps get rid of your delusions, misunderstandings and cravings.

Everyday Philosophy Guidelines

- The minimum humans can do to live a peaceful life is make peace with ourselves and live in harmony with our family and fulfill our social responsibilities.
- It is important to eliminate conflicts that poison relationships and bring immense sufferings.
- These guidelines are basic and similar to what most of the world religions teach. Along with keeping your personal integrity intact, you must consider the welfare of the ones who may get affected by your actions.
- One must try to exercise self control over his mind, body and speech.
- One should abstain from destroying life, stealing, sexual misconduct, lying and intoxicants.
- The person on the path to enlightenment should treat all beings with kindness and compassion and live a sober upright life.
- Fulfilling duties to parents, family and friends is important.
- Manifesto of peace
- Responding hatred with hatred will only breed more hatred and more violence leading to the vicious circle of vengeance and retaliation. Hatred should only be answered with love. You should learn to be patient and forgiving when someone wrongs you. In such circumstances, control your anger like a driver controls a chariot.
- The quality of generosity, truthfulness, patience and compassion distinguishes a superior human being from the ordinary ones.
- The scent of virtue, the Buddha declares, is sweeter than the scent of flowers and perfume.
- A good person will always outshine and like water his generosity will always find its way. Like a lotus always rises above the muck, the disciple of Buddha will rise above the mass of ignorant fools to attain wisdom.

Mindfulness:

Mindfulness meditation is good for your mental and physical health

I. It decreases the stress hormone cortisol and thus helps lower stress. II. It helps you conquer the common blind spot and analyse yourself in order to get to know your true self.

III. According to the researchers from the University of California, college students who practiced mindfulness meditation performed better in the verbal reasoning section of the GRE. The study says that it is an efficient way to improve your working memory with wide reaching consequences.

IV. It helps your brain have better control over processing pain and emotions, thus makes you feel more focused and Zen.

V. It helps you indulge in music in a way that you truly enjoy what you are listening to. VI.

There are four major elements of mindfulness – body-awareness, self-awareness, regulation of attention and regulation of emotion. The meditation practice helps you get consciousness to regulate all four elements.

VII. It lowers depression risk among teens and pregnant women. Researchers at the University

of Michigan say that mindfulness yoga lead to an empowered and positive feeling about

pregnancy. The teens that practice this technique through school programs experience less anxiety and stress.

VIII. According to a survey conducted by American Psychological Mindfulness Yoga and meditation is an excellent way to lose weight.

IX. One of the greatest benefits of mindfulness is that it helps you sleep better at night. According to experts, higher mindfulness is directly proportional to lower activation at bedtime. People who practice this technique enjoy quality sleep and develop ability to manage stress well.

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Mahavir & Jainism

Introduction to Mahavira

Mahavira was a wealthy prince named Vardhamana born in 599 BC in Bihar. He was 24th and last Tirthankara of the Jain religion. Jain philosophy believes that all Tirthankaras were born as normal or average human beings, but through meditation and self-actualization they attained the state of perfection and enlightenment, and became the gods of Jains.

Similar to the origin of Buddha, Lord Mahavira was the son of a king and blessed with many worldly pleasures. He chose to give up on material possessions at the age of thirty and left his home in search of the ultimate truth and for the meaning of life.

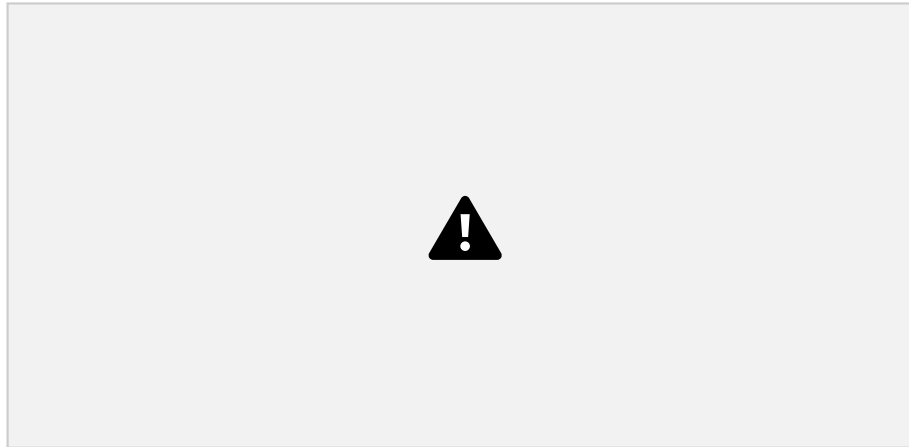
Ahimsa or nonviolence was one of his core teachings and practices, as he believed that every living being has a soul and it shouldn't be harmed. After leaving his home, Lord Mahavira spent 12 intense years in deep silence and meditation. During this time, he carefully avoided harming any living creature and sustained without food for long periods, enabling him a deeper spiritual connect, leading him to develop super powers. Due to unbearable hardships he had gone through, he was given the name Mahavira, meaning brave and courageous.

He then travelled all across the length and breadth of India, in order to preach to the people the eternal truth he had realised. His objective was to minimise the sufferings of people and show them the path of liberation and total freedom from pain, misery, and the cycle of life and death.

Lord Mahavira is widely regarded as the founder of Jainism as he persuaded the valuable

teachings of his predecessors, the 23 Tirthankaras or prophets. Lord Mahavira's immediate disciples were known as Gandharas and Srut-kevalis. These invaluable teachings of Lord Mahavira were later compiled by his disciples into the significant texts that now form the basis of Jain Literature.

The teachings of Mahavira were initially transferred orally from gurus to their disciples, as religious scriptures were considered as precious as materialistic possessions. And non possession or non-attachment is one of the five important vows of Jainism.



However, after one thousand years of Mahavira's death (niravana), it became difficult for Jain Acharyas to memorise everything taught by the scholars in the past. Unfortunately, significant amounts of knowledge were lost, others were modified and polluted, with no means to verify. The Archarayas then felt the need to document these texts.

At the same time, two major sects named Digambar and Shwetambar were formed. These two aspects have opposing views on the validity and acceptance of the now documented Jain Scriptures.

Jain literature is majorly divided into two categories

- B. Agam Literature (canonical texts):** Comprised of written Prakrit language, Agam literature constitutes original scriptures compiled by the Gandharas and elder monks, known as Srut-kevalis.
- C. Non- agam Literature (non-canonical texts):** Written in prakrit, Sanskrit, old Marathi, Gujarati, Hindi, Kannada, Tamil, German and English, non-agam literature constitutes commentaries and explanations of Agam Literature and independent works of scholars.

A. Agam Literature

Also known as Agam Sutras or Jain Agams, these scriptures are considered as sacred books of Jain literature. While other religions have the Gita, the Bible or the Quran, Jainism does not have any sacred book. Instead, the scriptures of Jainism have multiple sacred sutras. Each teaching is a great reverence for all forms of life, Agam sutras constitute strict codes of nonviolence, vege-tarianism, non-possession, and compassion. Agam Lit-erature is further divided into two groups - Ang Agams and Angbahya Agams. Ang sutras are direct teachings of Lord Mahavira and Angbahya are the commentaries and explanations of Agam sutras.

B. Digambar Literature

According to Digambar Literture, there were total 26 Agam sutras and all of them were lost over the years. Because of this belief, the followers of Digambar sect do not consider agam sutras as authentic scriptures. The religious scriptures that the followers of this sect believe in

are the ones written by Great Acharayas from 100 to 1000 AD. The basis of their work is the original agam sutras.

Five main principles propagated by Lord Mahavira

A. Belief in soul and Karma: Mahavira believed that every living creature or anything that breathes has a soul. The soul is held in a constant state of bondage due to Karma- the natural consequence of our thoughts, words and actions. The soul, how-ever, can be liberated from this bondage by disintegrating Karmic force and freedom from worldly attachments and possessions.

When the soul crumbles the cycle of Karma, one can feel the innate power and intrinsic value of soul. The soul (atma) becomes parmatama when it attains infinite greatness and shines to its full radiance. Hence, Jains do not believe in worshipping one particular god. In fact, they admire the liber-ated souls of Tirthankaras who attained nirvana.

B.Niravana:

Mahavira, the enlightened, believed that the ultimate objective of life is to achieve salvation. He insists that one should avoid the evil karmas done in the past and prevent indulging in new evil karmas. This can be achieved by following the five important vows: • Non-violence (Ahimsa)

- Speaking truth (Satya)
- Non-stealing (Asteya),
- Non-adultery (Brahmacharya)
- Non-possession (Aparigraha)

In addition to these vows, Mahavira also throws light on the principles of right conduct, right knowledge, and right faith. While these vows and principles are for householders, there are strict codes for monks in Jain scriptures.

C. Non-belief in God:

Mahavira believed that universe has no starting and end and hence there is no creator or destroyer of the universe. The universe and its elements simply change their form. This means the liberation of man does not depend on any outside authority; man is the maker and destroyer of his own destiny. He can get rid of his miseries and sorrows by subduing the bodily desires and leading the path of austerity. According to him, renunciation is the best way to achieve salvation.

D. Ahimsa:

Ahimsa is one of the most significant principles persuaded by Mahavira. Ma-havira believed that every creature including animals, plants, stones and rocks etc has life and it shouldn't be harmed come what may. Jains took greatly to the concept of to Ahimsa, popularised it and put an end to sacrifices.

E. Freedom to women:

Mahavira believed in the freedom and liberation of women. According to him, the right to attain nirvana is equally important for women. At a time when sages and wise men did not pay attention to the condition of women, Mahavira wanted them to be on the same level as

men. Mahavira was not a believer in the caste system and distinction of classes on the basis of that.

Modern Outlook of Jainism: Inception of modern concepts for the upliftment of society.

Besides discovering “brahmi and other lipis”, the first Tirthankara of Jainism Lord Rsabhadeva started sowing the seeds for future generations by introducing the concepts of Reading, Writing and Arithmetic. Also, the Bhagwad Purana of the Hindus has some reference to Jainism. The three great religions of India, Hinduism, Jainism and Buddhism, have played a significant role in shaping the culture and civilization of India. The ultimate aim of these three religions is the attainment of “moksha” or absolution “niravana”. The subjects of cooking, building, construction, reading writings have been taught to Jain monks, laymen and women by Rsabhadeva. These teachings enabled them to lead fulfilling social lives, while preserving and sustaining Indian Culture.

The Indian King Siddharaja offered great respect to Jainism and educated people about literature, art, sculpture, painting and music under its influence. The great King Akbar is said to pay heed to Jain pontiffs and persuaded Jainism to shape the culture of India. There have been several Jain monks well-known for their contributions to literary accomplishments. These monks have explained the brilliant concepts of astronomy, astrology, prosody and didactic literature through dramas, kathas and scientific literature.

Video

<https://youtu.be/KAc33hNc7ak>

Jainism in the current scenario

Looking at the current day scenario where wars are constantly happening between countries for possession of land and its resources, Jain practices like Ahimsa and Aparigraha (non possession) are of great importance when used astutely and wisely. These practices can go a long way when it comes reshaping the life of people socially and economically. Jain scripture as well as, other ancient scriptures say the first 25 years is the Brahmacharya life, in other words, it is the time you spend on acquiring knowledge and not on pleasure or pleasurable activities. Unfortunately we flout all that is laid down in our scriptures because of ignorance of our own scriptures. Our youth craves for guidance but it is not forthcoming from adults which is their irresponsibility.

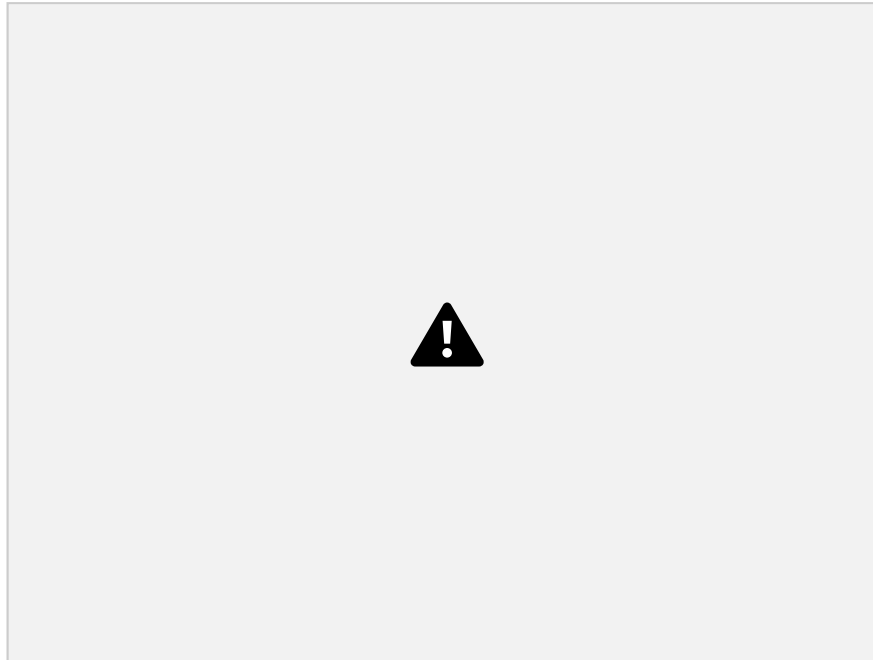
Jainism opened its door for anyone and everyone, irrespective of one's caste colour and creed. There is no concept of untouchability and class system, as the religion believes in humanism or the equality of human beings. The five Mahavratas of Jainism can help set up a new value system that can help tackle modern day problems like bad eating, drinking and overall lifestyle of current generation. These problems are corroding the life of individuals.

Jainism can be reformed to form a new value system

Like Mahavira reformed the existing religion to fit in the value system of current generation, Jainism can be reformed, rationalized and re-oriented to adapt with the change in time. Religions cannot be static; instead they should be dynamic to ensure that the past glory perfectly translates into permanent reality. The Jain philosophy of understanding and respecting others views is quite progressive and has the potential to bring about a synthesis between its ancient doctrines and social, economic and cultural needs of the current century.

Conclusion: Change is the only constant

Jainism is more of moral code than a religion that believes in a supreme being. However, it reveres the individuals who understood their higher consciousness and became spiritually great. The most progressive thing about Jainism is that it did not dogmatise, according to its fundamental logic there is no absolute affirmation and denial. If necessity arose, Jainism will not be unwilling to accept the existence of Supreme Being. The power of accommodation and dynamism is that the religion survived in India till date.

What is the similarity between Buddhism and Jainism?**Three jewels in Jain philosophy****Right belief**

The first step to self-actualization is adopting a rational attitude in life and renouncing superstitious beliefs. Right perception means one should be able to see and understand the true nature of every substance in the universe. One should not only try to understand the nature of reality, but also understand one's own self, religious goals and the path that needs to be followed to achieve them. To invest in one's full faith in preaching of Tirthankas, one should know, analyze, verify, test and be satisfied of its nature of reality and efficacy.

Right knowledge

Right knowledge means the true and relevant knowledge of reality. To understand reality, it is important to understand the elements of the universe and their relationship. Essentially, it means the proper knowledge of six universal substances and 9 tattvas. While the six substances include soul, matter, motion, rest, space and time, nine tattvas include soul, matter, asrava, bandh, punya, papa, samvara, nirjara, and Moksha.

Right Conduct

Proper, appropriate, correct and honest conduct of human soul is called known as Right Conduct. The aim of human soul is to attain the state of perfect equanimity. This can only be achieved by liberating yourself from attachment, aversion and impure thoughts, words and deeds. To practice the principles of self-realization, one needs to have right conduct, which comprises ethical codes, roles and disciplines.

The Jain theory of Non absolutism and Syadvada